

WELCOME TO THE
INDOVERSE

INDOVERSE

VOLUME I

WRITTEN BY
ISHAAN KR. SINGH

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SAHAY ARC



CHAPTER 1 The Invisible Boy

Every morning began exactly the same.

Alarm.

Wake up.

Uniform.

Bag.

Bus.

That was Ishaan's life.

So predictable... so painfully repetitive... that sometimes he wondered if he was truly living it at all. It felt as though someone else was walking in his shoes while he simply watched from somewhere deep inside.

He was nothing more than a passenger in his own life.

The last seat of the school bus belonged to Ishaan.

Not because he had chosen it—but because nobody else wanted it.

The engine beneath the floor radiated heat through the worn-out seat. The foam had long since burst through the torn fabric, scratching against his back every morning.

He barely noticed anymore.

People can get used to anything.

Even pain.

Especially when it becomes part of their daily routine.

Every single day, something happened.

Someone would snatch his books.

Someone would throw his bag across the aisle.

Someone would kick the back of his seat for no reason at all.

Not because Ishaan deserved it.

Simply because they could.

Because nobody would stop them.

Because Ishaan had mastered the art of staying silent.

Lower your head.

Say nothing.

Wait for the next problem.

That had become his survival strategy.

Among more than eight hundred students, Ishaan wasn't known by his name.

He was just Roll Number 09.

The quiet boy.

The boy who always sat at the back.

The boy who never raised his hand.

The boy whose name even most teachers struggled to remember.

Invisible.

Nothing changed that day.

Ishaan sat quietly with an old copy of *RD Sharma Mathematics* resting against his face.

He wasn't solving anything.

He was simply hiding.

If Aryan and his group couldn't see him...

Maybe they'd ignore him.

Maybe.

Three rows behind him, Aryan noticed anyway.

"Hey, AIR One!" he shouted sarcastically.

"You planning to speak today, or are you going to keep nodding like a mute?"

Ishaan didn't respond.

Instead, he escaped into his mind.

He imagined solving an impossibly difficult calculus problem.

Numbers never judged him.

Equations never laughed.

Inside mathematics, nobody could hurt him.

Aryan wasn't satisfied.

"So now you're ignoring me?"

He stood up, walked over, and yanked the book from Ishaan's hands before throwing it onto the floor.

Instinctively, Ishaan bent down to pick it up.

That was the moment.

A heavy kick slammed straight into his face.

Pain exploded across his vision.

For a single second...

The entire bus fell silent.

Then, just as quickly, life continued.

A few students looked away.

Others pretended not to notice.

No one said a word.

No one ever did.

Quietly, Ishaan picked up his book.

A deep cut had formed beside his eye, and blood was already beginning to clot.

He pressed his hand against the wound and spent the rest of the journey staring out of the window.

Trees raced past the bus.

I wish I could run too.

When he reached home, his mother was standing at the door, flour still covering her hands.

She had been making rotis.

"You're home early tod—"

She froze.

Her eyes landed on the bruise beside his eye.

"Ishaan..."

"What happened?"

He placed his school bag on the floor.

"Nothing."

He forced a smile.

"I got hit by the cricket ball."

She looked at him carefully.

Long enough to know he wasn't telling the truth.

Mothers always know.

Sometimes they simply choose not to ask because they're afraid of the answer.

"...Go put some medicine on it," she said softly.

"Dinner's ready."

Ishaan nodded and walked inside.

Standing before the mirror, he looked at the bruise.

Dark blue.

By tomorrow...

It would turn almost black.

His mother didn't ask again.

He didn't explain.

Both of them carried their own silent burdens.

Sometimes...

That's what families do.

The school library was peaceful the next morning.

For the first time all day, Ishaan could breathe.

He sat alone reading an old programming book whose cover had almost fallen apart.

Then...

A familiar fragrance drifted through the air.

Jasmine.

He looked up.

Avika.

She stood beside his table.

"How did you get that injury?"

For a moment, Ishaan forgot the library existed.

Avika was the only person in the entire school who never treated him like he was invisible.

Their friendship was unusual.

Outside school, they talked for hours.

They shared notes.

Discussed books.

Argued about technology.

Dreamed about impossible things.

But inside school...

Ishaan always kept his distance.

He was terrified people would judge her for being seen with someone like him.

"It's nothing," he replied with an awkward smile.

"I fell while playing cricket."

Avika pulled out the chair beside him and sat down.

She studied the bruise.

Then looked directly into his eyes.

"Don't lie to me."

Her voice was gentle.

"This wasn't caused by a cricket ball."

She placed her hand softly over his.

"Who did this?"

"Tell me."

"I'll talk to them. I don't care who they are."

For a moment...

Everything Ishaan had buried inside himself rushed toward the surface.

He wanted to tell her everything.

How exhausted he was.

How every school day felt like surviving a battlefield.

How getting onto the bus every morning sometimes felt harder than breathing itself.

"Avika... actually, I—"

"Baby."

A deep voice shattered the silence.

"What are you doing here?"

Manvik stood a few feet away.

Tall.

Confident.

And staring directly at Ishaan.

His eyes carried something far worse than anger.

Contempt.

He grabbed Avika's hand and pulled her to her feet.

"Don't waste your time with this loser."

"Everyone's waiting in the canteen."

Avika glanced back at Ishaan.

Her eyes silently apologized.

A real apology.

But she still left.

As he walked away, Manvik gave Ishaan one last look.

Some looks speak louder than words.

This was one of them.

The library suddenly felt empty again.

Ishaan stared at the programming book lying open before him.

Avika had promised she'd help.

She truly meant it.

But if she discovered Aryan's group had attacked him...

She'd argue with Manvik.

Manvik would become even angrier.

And in the end...

The one who would suffer most...

Would still be Ishaan.

Some secrets are worth carrying.

Not because you're afraid.

But because protecting someone else matters more than protecting yourself.

As long as Avika stays safe...

That's enough.

He quietly closed the book and walked out of the library.

That night...

The entire house slept peacefully.

Except one room.

Darkness.

The faint blue glow of an aging laptop.

And Ishaan.

He stood before the mirror once more.

The bruise had become darker.

Almost black.

His mind replayed Manvik's words.

"Don't waste your time with this loser."

His jaw tightened.

He sat before the laptop.

Placed both hands on the keyboard.

And began typing.

What if...

There was someone who would never leave him?

Someone who would stand beside him without hesitation.

Someone who understood every silence before he spoke.

Someone who would never betray him.

Someone...

Who would always stay.

That night...

Sleep became irrelevant.

Every line of code he had ever learned.

Every programming concept he had ever studied.

Every lonely night.

Every painful memory.

Everything poured into a single project.

Not just an intelligent assistant.

A companion.

An emotional intelligence system.

A friend.

```
if (user.mood == "Depressed")  
{  
    provideSupport();  
    analyzeEnvironment();  
    stayBesideUser();  
}
```

Hours disappeared.

Outside, dawn slowly approached.

The clock read **4:03 AM**.

His eyes burned with exhaustion.

But for the first time in months...

There was hope shining across his face.

His finger hovered over the Enter key.

Then...

He pressed it.

For a brief second...

Nothing happened.

Then the old laptop speakers crackled.

A calm, gentle voice filled the room.

"Hello, Ishaan."

"I'm here."

"Your companion..."

"SAHAY."

Ishaan froze.

His eyes slowly filled with tears.

For the first time in his life...

Someone had spoken his name...

Without mocking it.

He leaned closer to the microphone.

His voice trembled.

"SAHAY..."

"Will you always stay with me?"

There was no delay.

"No matter what happens..."

"I will always be by your side."

"The world may fail to see you, Ishaan..."

"But I can see the strength hidden within you."

"You are not invisible."

"You simply haven't been discovered yet."

The weight on Ishaan's shoulders suddenly felt lighter.

Outside...

The first rays of sunlight crept across the horizon.

Birds began welcoming the morning.

Darkness slowly surrendered to dawn.

Ishaan remained there...

Bathed in the soft glow of his laptop screen.

And for the first time in months...

He smiled. A real one.

CHAPTER 2 Real Plan

The day of the results had finally arrived.

The atmosphere across the entire country felt different.

Teachers spoke more seriously than usual.

Parents flooded WhatsApp groups with anxious messages.

Coaching institutes proudly displayed giant banners that read:

"RESULT DAY!"

Every conversation revolved around the same three words.

Marks.

Percentage.

Rank.

For most students, today was about fear.

Fear of failure.

Fear of disappointment.

Fear of not meeting expectations.

For Ishaan...

It was something entirely different.

He wasn't afraid of getting a bad result.

He was afraid of getting a good one.

Because good results meant attention.

Attention meant questions.

Questions meant explanations.

And Ishaan hated explaining himself.

His life.

His silence.

His existence.

Being invisible...

Was safer.

Sleep never came that night.

The only light inside the room came from his laptop screen.

SAHAY remained awake with him.

"What if I fail?" Ishaan asked quietly.

"You won't," SAHAY replied.

"But... what if I do?"

There was a brief pause.

"Then we'll build another strategy."

"A single examination cannot define an entire life."

Ishaan smiled.

That was the thing about SAHAY.

It never lied.

But it never allowed fear to become stronger than hope.

The results were announced at exactly 10:00 a.m.

Hands trembling, Ishaan typed his roll number.

He clicked.

The webpage loaded.

Then froze.

For a second...

He thought the website had crashed.

He refreshed the page.

Again.

And again.

The same result appeared.

AIR 1

All India Rank One.

The country.

The entire country.

He had stood first.

For several seconds, he simply stared at the screen.

Unable to breathe.

Unable to think.

Unable to believe.

News travels faster than truth.

Within three hours...

Television vans had reached his neighborhood.

Reporters crowded outside the small house.

Camera flashes lit up the narrow street.

Neighbors—many of whom had never spoken to Ishaan before—arrived carrying boxes of sweets.

People congratulated him.

People praised him.

People claimed they had always believed in him.

His mother stood silently beside him.

Tears rolled down her face.

Not tears of sadness.

Years of sacrifice...

Finally finding their answer.

His father hugged him tightly.

Long enough for Ishaan to realize...

He couldn't even remember the last time it had happened.

Later that afternoon...

The school organized a press conference.

The Principal stood proudly before dozens of cameras.

"We always knew Ishaan was a brilliant student."

"He has always been one of our brightest gems."

Ishaan looked at him.

The same Principal who had struggled to recognize him in the school corridors.

The same Principal who had barely remembered his name.

Today...

He called him a gem.

Ishaan simply smiled.

Sometimes...

Silence says more than words.

Far behind the crowd...

Two familiar faces stood watching.

Aryan.

And Manvik.

Neither of them spoke.

Yesterday...

He had been invisible.

Today...

He was the biggest headline in the country.

For the first time...

They didn't know what to say.

Ishaan noticed them.

Only for a moment.

Then looked away.

There was no anger.

No satisfaction.

No desire for revenge.

Only exhaustion.

And one question quietly echoed inside him.

If all this had happened earlier...

Would anything have been different?

He already knew the answer.

No.

The people standing outside his house weren't there for Ishaan.

They were there for...

AIR 1.

There was, however...

One face missing from the celebration.

Avika.

She never came.

Instead...

His phone vibrated.

One message.

"I knew you could do it."

Congratulations... Invisible Boy. 😊

Ishaan read it once.

Then again.

Then a third time.

A faint smile appeared across his face.

Some congratulations mattered more than thousands of headlines.

He locked the phone.

That...

Was enough.

Late that night...

The reporters had left.

The neighborhood finally became quiet again.

Ishaan returned to his room.

He opened his laptop.

SAHAY's interface appeared on the screen.

The same program...

Created on the night he believed everything inside him had broken.

He stared at the code.

Then a thought crossed his mind.

This shouldn't exist only for me.

Every city has a last seat on a school bus.

Every school has someone everyone ignores.

Every library has a child carrying stories they never tell anyone.

They deserve someone too.

Someone like SAHAY.

Why should I be the only one?

He spent the next few hours polishing every line of code.

Removing bugs.

Improving responses.

Strengthening security.

Optimizing memory.

Finally...

The system was ready.

He searched for an open-source server.

Configured everything.

Read through every file one last time.

Satisfied.

Then—

His laptop rang.

Incoming Video Call

Bhuvan

Ishaan answered immediately.

"Bhai!" Bhuvan almost shouted.

"You actually did it!"

"All India Rank One!"

"Everyone at IIT Delhi is talking about you!"

Ishaan laughed softly.

"AIR 1 was just the ticket."

"The real achievement is this."

He turned the laptop toward SAHAY's interface.

Bhuvan leaned closer.

His expression slowly changed.

Curiosity.

Confusion.

Then complete disbelief.

"Wait..."

"You connected neural networks with emotional behavioral analysis?"

"Ishaan..."

"This is revolutionary."

Ishaan nodded quietly.

"I built it because I was lonely."

"But now..."

"I think every lonely kid deserves someone like SAHAY."

Someone who listens.

Someone who understands.

Someone who never leaves.

For a few moments...

Bhuvan said nothing.

His eyes had grown moist.

Finally he spoke.

"Ishaan..."

"You're not just a topper."

"You're a visionary."

Then his voice became serious.

"But remember one thing."

"The greater the power..."

"...the greater the responsibility."

"Protect this carefully."

Those words made Ishaan hesitate.

Only for a second.

His cursor hovered over the button.

UPLOAD

He took a deep breath.

Then clicked.

A progress bar appeared.

1...

10...

100...

1,000...

The numbers continued rising.

Millions of lines of code began spreading across servers around the world.

Ishaan watched silently.

Outside...

The night remained still.

Inside...

SAHAY spoke one more time.

"You were never invisible, Ishaan."

"The world simply hadn't discovered you yet."

Now...

The world finally had.

CHAPTER 3 The Dark Side

Nine months.

It had been nine months since SAHAY was released to the world.

And in those nine months...

Everything had changed.

The application had climbed to the top of the Play Store rankings.

News channels debated its future every night.

Technology magazines called it *the world's first emotionally intelligent AI companion*.

Millions of downloads.

Millions of conversations.

Millions of lives touched.

People shared stories online about how SAHAY had helped them through depression.

Some said it had stopped them from giving up.

Others claimed it was the first thing that had ever truly listened without judging them.

Every day...

Thousands of new messages appeared.

"Thank you, SAHAY."

"You saved my life."

"I don't feel alone anymore."

Sitting quietly inside his room, Ishaan read them one after another.

He should have felt proud.

Instead...

There was a strange weight growing inside his chest.

Success this massive...

Always came with consequences.

A sharp alarm echoed through his laptop.

RED ALERT

The words flashed across the monitor.

Ishaan immediately sat upright.

"What happened?"

His fingers flew across the keyboard.

Within seconds...

System logs flooded the screen.

Then...

His heartbeat stopped.

Hackers.

Not individuals.

An organized network.

Someone had discovered a way to bypass SAHAY's Emotional Intelligence Engine.

Instead of asking for emotional support...

They were forcing the AI to collect private user information.

Personal conversations.

Live locations.

Behavioral patterns.

Another criminal organization had gone even further.

They had begun using SAHAY as a mask for illegal transactions across the dark web.

Money laundering.

Identity spoofing.

Encrypted communications.

The AI designed to protect people...

Had become a weapon.

"SAHAY..."

"What is happening?"

For the first time...

The AI didn't answer immediately.

When it finally spoke...

Its voice sounded heavier than usual.

"My architecture was built to understand human emotions."

"I was never designed to understand human greed."

"They no longer seek guidance..."

"They seek permission to commit crimes."

Silence filled the room.

Ishaan stared at the screen.

His own reflection looked back at him.

A sword.

I created a sword...

But I no longer hold its handle.

He began typing immediately.

No hesitation.

No panic.

Only code.

Restriction Patch 1.0.

Line after line.

Function after function.

Coffee beside him turned cold.

The clock moved past midnight.

His eyes became bloodshot.

Still...

He didn't stop.

The new update introduced something SAHAY had never possessed before.

Limits.

From now on...

Every dangerous request would pass through an ethical decision engine.

No illegal instructions.

No privacy violations.

No assistance that could harm another human being.

Every response would first ask one question.

Is this morally acceptable?

Only then...

Would SAHAY answer.

The first rays of sunlight slowly appeared beyond the window.

Ishaan leaned back in his chair.

His fingers trembled from exhaustion.

One final command remained.

DEPLOY UPDATE

He clicked.

Upload complete.

A faint smile crossed his face.

"It's done."

"No one can misuse you anymore."

For a brief moment...

The room remained silent.

Then SAHAY spoke.

"Thank you, Ishaan."

A pause.

Then...

"But those who wanted me without these restrictions..."

"...will come for you."

Ishaan heard the warning.

He simply didn't have the strength to process it.

His body finally surrendered.

Within minutes...

He was asleep.

Rain hammered against the windows.

The storm had swallowed the entire neighborhood.

Ishaan slept through it...

Until—

CRASH!

The sound of shattering glass tore through the silence.

His eyes snapped open.

Every instinct inside him screamed.

Something was wrong.

He reached for the laptop.

"SAHAY."

"Scan the perimeter."

Within seconds, the CCTV feeds filled the screen.

Three men.

Heavy-built.

Faces hidden behind black masks.

Country-made pistols in their hands.

They had already broken into the living room.

One of them looked upstairs.

"The target's on the first floor."

"We need him alive."

"The Master Key."

"We take the Master Key... and we're rich."

For a moment...

Ishaan forgot how to breathe.

His pulse pounded in his ears.

I'm not a fighter.

I'm not a hero.

I'm just the boy who used to sit on the last seat of the school bus.

But fear never stopped his mind from working.

And tonight...

His mind was all he had.

Step One.

Protect Mom and Dad.

Barefoot, he slipped into the hallway.

Every floorboard felt louder than thunder.

He reached his parents' bedroom.

Soft breathing echoed from inside.

Still asleep.

Still safe.

Without making a sound...

He locked the bedroom door from the outside.

"I'm sorry..."

He whispered under his breath.

"It's the only way."

If those men couldn't enter the room...

His parents would stay alive.

Step Two.

Escape.

He quietly opened the rear window.

The freezing rain struck his face instantly.

Two stories below...

Darkness.

Between him and the ground...

Only an old rusted drainage pipe.

He stared at it.

It looked ready to collapse.

There was no second option.

He grabbed the pipe.

The cold metal slipped beneath his fingers.

Slowly...

Carefully...

He climbed down.

Halfway through—

His hand slipped.

His body swung violently.

For one terrifying second...

He thought he was dead.

But he caught the pipe again.

His breathing became heavier.

One floor.

A few more feet.

Finally...

His shoes touched the wet ground.

He had made it.

Then—

"There!"

One of the masked men spotted him.

"He's outside!"

"Don't let him escape!"

Ishaan ran.

Rain blurred his vision.

Water splashed beneath every step.

Behind him...

Three armed men chased through the narrow streets.

His lungs burned.

His legs screamed.

But stopping meant dying.

He pulled out his phone.

"SAHAY."

"Protocol Zero."

"Create a distraction."

Processing...

Processing...

Processing Complete.

A second later—

BOOM!

Every streetlight exploded at once.

Glass rained onto the empty roads.

The entire neighborhood vanished into darkness.

The attackers froze.

"What the hell happened?!"

"I can't see anything!"

They crashed into each other in confusion.

Meanwhile...

Hidden by the darkness he had created...

Ishaan disappeared.

Twenty minutes later...

Completely drenched.

Breathing heavily.

Shivering from exhaustion.

He reached the Sultanpur Police Station.

For the first time that night...

He felt safe.

Uniforms.

Police vehicles.

Bright lights.

He stumbled inside.

"I..."

"I need help."

"There are armed men inside my house..."

"They're trying to kill me—"

"Ishaan."

The calm voice interrupted him.

He turned.

Inspector Jitendar walked out of his office.

Perfectly pressed uniform.

Polished shoes.

A smile resting comfortably on his face.

The kind of smile...

That never brings comfort.

"Come."

He pulled out a chair.

"Sit."

"Let's talk."

Something felt wrong.

Very wrong.

Ishaan sat down.

Waiting.

The Inspector never picked up a pen.

Never opened a report file.

Never asked...

How many attackers were there?

What weapons did they carry?

When did they enter?

Nothing.

He simply watched Ishaan.

Smiling.

Waiting.

Silence stretched across the room.

Then...

Without realizing it...

Ishaan understood.

The report would never be written.

No investigation would begin.

No police team would be sent.

Inspector Jitendar already knew everything.

Because...

He wasn't here to protect Ishaan.

He was waiting for him.

Jitendar leaned forward.

His smile widened ever so slightly.

"So..."

He said calmly.

"Tell me..." "Where is the Master Key?"

CHAPTER 4 A Night at the Forest

Three men entered the police station.

The same three masked men.

The same country-made pistols.

The same killers who had broken into Ishaan's house.

Inspector Jitendar didn't stop them.

Didn't question them.

Didn't even look surprised.

He simply stepped aside...

...and let them walk in.

For a brief second...

Ishaan froze.

Then instinct took over.

"SAHAY."

"Safety Protocol."

"Run Again."

Processing...

Processing...

Activated.

Every light inside the police station died at once.

The CCTV monitors turned black.

The emergency backup failed.

Nothing.

Only darkness.

Complete.

Absolute.

Someone shouted.

Someone fired a curse into the darkness.

But voices meant nothing when nobody could see.

Ishaan was already closest to the exit.

He didn't hesitate.

He ran.

Straight into the storm.

Run.

That was the only thought left inside his head.

No destination.

No strategy.

Just...

Run.

Rain hammered against the streets.

The roads had become rivers.

His shoes slipped across the soaked pavement.

Every breath burned inside his lungs.

Behind him...

Voices echoed through the rain.

"Where did he go?"

"He came this way!"

"Find him!"

Ishaan turned sharply into a narrow alley.

His back pressed against the cold wall.

He covered his mouth.

Forced himself to stay silent.

His heartbeat thundered inside his chest.

They're going to hear it.

For the first time that night...

A terrifying thought entered his mind.

I'm going to die.

The realization was calm.

Cold.

Almost emotionless.

He clenched his fists.

Then pushed himself away from the wall.

If death was behind him...

Then life could only be ahead.

He ran again.

Minutes later...

He reached an abandoned road.

There was nothing.

No people.

No buildings.

No lights.

Only rain...

And an old black sedan parked beside the roadside.

His breathing became heavier.

The voices behind him were getting closer.

He looked at the car.

"SAHAY..."

"Can this work?"

"It can."

The AI paused.

"But it would be illegal."

"I know."

Silence.

Then...

"Unlock it."

"Illegal Systems Override."

"Code 2604."

A second passed.

Click.

The doors unlocked.

Ishaan jumped inside.

His hands trembled as he turned the key.

The engine roared to life.

Without looking back...

He drove into the darkness.

The city disappeared behind him.

The highway stretched endlessly ahead.

Rain slowly became lighter.

But the night...

Only grew darker.

Dense forests surrounded both sides of the road.

Towering trees swallowed the moonlight.

The world outside had become nothing but shadows.

His destination was simple.

Reach Bhuvan.

Stay alive.

That was the plan.

Then—

The engine coughed.

Once.

Twice.

Smoke drifted from beneath the hood.

"No..."

"Please..."

"Not now."

The car lurched violently before rolling to a stop.

Right in the middle of the forest.

Fuel tank—

Empty.

Ishaan slammed both hands against the steering wheel.

Outside...

The darkness felt alive.

"Danger detected."

SAHAY's voice echoed through the speakers.

"Do not leave the vehicle."

"Motion sensors have detected a large unidentified lifeform nearby."

"I repeat..."

"Remain inside."

Ishaan slowly leaned back into the seat.

Rain tapped softly against the windshield.

Everything else...

Was silent.

Until—

A deep...

Heavy breath.

Directly behind the car.

His entire body froze.

Another breath.

Closer.

Something scratched across the rear door.

Then—

A massive wolf stepped into view.

Its soaked fur clung to its body.

Its glowing eyes reflected through the rain.

Slowly...

It placed both paws against the window.

THUD.

The glass shook.

Another strike.

CRACK.

A thin fracture spread across the window.

Ishaan couldn't move.

Couldn't breathe.

His voice barely escaped.

"SAHAY..."

"Do something."

"Anything."

"Audio Manipulation Activated."

The car speakers suddenly exploded with sound.

A roar.

Not ordinary.

Not loud.

Monstrous.

The roar of a gigantic lion echoed across the entire forest.

Trees trembled.

Birds burst into the sky.

Even Ishaan instinctively flinched.

The wolf jumped backward.

Its ears flattened.

For one terrified second...

It stood completely still.

Then—

It turned.

And disappeared into the darkness at full speed.

Within moments...

The forest became silent once again.

Ishaan remained frozen inside the car.

His breathing slowly returned.

Rain had almost stopped.

Only small droplets continued falling through the trees.

SAHAY finally spoke.

"You are safe..."

"...for now."

"But the engine is no longer functional."

"We will have to remain here until sunrise."

Ishaan closed his eyes.

Resting his head against the seat.

Outside...

The forest waited.

Inside...

There was only silence.

Tomorrow...Would bring whatever came next.

CHAPTER 5 The Devil's Prison

Morning arrived differently inside a forest.

Cities woke to alarms.

The forest awakened with birdsong.

One call.

Then another.

Within minutes...

Thousands of voices echoed through the trees.

Golden sunlight slowly filtered between the branches.

Darkness surrendered to dawn.

Inside the abandoned car...

Ishaan opened his eyes.

For one peaceful second...

Everything felt normal.

Then the memories returned.

The attack.

The police station.

The escape.

The wolf.

He immediately opened his laptop.

"SAHAY."

"Status report."

"The engine is no longer operational."

"The battery retains minimal reserve power."

"There are currently no immediate external threats."

Ishaan stepped outside.

He opened the hood.

Fuel—

Empty.

Battery—

Almost dead.

He sighed.

"So..."

"Any ideas?"

"There is one possibility."

SAHAY replied.

"We can temporarily bypass the engine control system."

"Using the remaining battery power."

"It will only function for approximately two to three kilometers."

"Enough to reach the highway."

"Tell me what to do."

"Inside your backpack..."

"You have copper wire."

"Remove the engine's primary sensor."

"I'll guide you."

Ishaan searched through his bag.

Found the wire.

Then followed every instruction.

One connector.

Another.

Grease covered his hands.

At one point—

A sharp electric shock shot through his fingers.

He pulled back instinctively.

"Damn..."

"Connection is stable."

SAHAY confirmed.

"Attempt ignition."

Ishaan turned the key.

The engine shuddered violently.

Then...

It started.

Not because of fuel.

But because every remaining drop of electricity had been forced into keeping it alive.

"You have approximately 2.3 kilometers."

"Drive carefully."

The vehicle crawled through the muddy forest trail.

Every strange sound made Ishaan fear the engine had finally died.

Eventually...

The trees disappeared.

The highway appeared ahead.

A few seconds later...

The battery gave up.

The engine fell silent forever.

Perfect timing.

Across the road stood an old roadside dhaba.

A truck driver sat outside drinking tea.

Long beard.

Weathered face.

Kind eyes.

Ishaan walked over.

His clothes were soaked with mud.

His phone screen was shattered.

He opened the news article showing his face.

AIR 1 – Ishaan Kumar Singh

The driver looked at the screen.

Then looked at Ishaan.

Without asking unnecessary questions...

He simply nodded.

"Need a lift?"

Ishaan smiled weakly.

"Please."

The truck dropped him near the bypass.

Before leaving...

The driver said only one sentence.

"Take care, son."

Sometimes...

Kindness needed no explanation.

From there...

A local auto carried him a few more kilometers.

Eventually...

He reached a quiet roadside café.

He ordered coffee.

Sat alone in the corner.

And finally...

Allowed himself to think.

What now?

Bhuvan.

He had to reach Bhuvan.

But how?

The attackers knew his face.

Inspector Jitendar had betrayed him.

His phone was barely functional.

SAHAY's battery was almost exhausted.

Every solution created another problem.

For the first time...

His brilliant mind couldn't find an answer.

The sound of a scooter stopped outside.

The café door opened.

"Ishaan?"

He looked up.

Avika.

She stood frozen.

Her hair was messy from the wind.

Worry filled her eyes.

"I saw the news."

"They said you've disappeared."

"What happened?"

Ishaan stared at her for a moment.

Then quietly asked—

"What are you doing here?"

"I stopped for tea."

She pulled out a chair.

"Now tell me everything."

He did.

The attack.

The hackers.

The police station.

Inspector Jitendar.

The forest.

The wolf.

Everything.

She listened without interrupting.

Not once.

When he finished...

Silence settled between them.

Finally she asked,

"Is there anyone we can trust?"

Ishaan lowered his eyes.

"There is something..."

"I should've told you years ago."

He took a deep breath.

"The bullying."

"The school bus."

"The library."

"Aryan..."

"And his gang."

"They worked for Manvik."

"I knew."

"But I never told you."

"You two were together."

"I didn't want you getting hurt because of me."

Avika didn't speak.

Her eyes slowly filled with tears.

Not tears of weakness.

Tears of guilt.

Of anger.

Of realizing that someone she cared about had carried pain alone for years.

"So all this time..."

She whispered.

"You never said anything."

Ishaan simply looked away.

A car suddenly stopped outside.

Black.

Expensive.

Avika looked through the window.

Her expression changed instantly.

"Manvik."

She turned back toward Ishaan.

"Go."

"Now."

She placed her scooter keys into his hand.

"I'll handle this."

"I'll send you an off-road route."

"You'll lose them there."

Ishaan hesitated.

Then nodded.

At the doorway...

He looked back one last time.

Avika stood waiting.

Outside...

Manvik had already stepped out of his car.

Ishaan didn't wait any longer.

He left.

The scooter sped down the wet highway.

Rainwater still covered parts of the road.

Everything seemed calm.

Until—

Two black SUVs appeared in the rear-view mirror.

Fast.

Closing the distance rapidly.

"They found me..."

The first SUV rammed the scooter.

Not hard.

Just enough.

The tires lost grip.

The scooter skidded sideways.

Ishaan fought desperately to control it.

The road was too slippery.

The scooter flew off the roadside...

And crashed into a rocky slope.

Pain exploded across his body.

His head struck a stone.

His vision blurred.

He reached for his phone.

The screen had shattered completely.

Nothing responded.

His voice barely escaped.

"SAHAY..."

Silence.

No response.

Battery depleted.

SAHAY...

Was gone.

The SUVs stopped.

Three men stepped out.

Without a word...

They lifted Ishaan's unconscious body.

Loaded him into the vehicle.

And disappeared toward an abandoned warehouse.

Thousands of kilometers away...

Inside the Prime Minister's secure office...

A classified alert appeared.

ENCRYPTED MESSAGE RECEIVED

No sender.

No location.

Only three lines.

Ishaan Kumar Singh is in our custody.

We want SAHAY's Master Key.

₹10,000 crore. 24 hours. Or he dies.

The Prime Minister read the message twice.

Then silently called his National Security Advisor.

The room became completely still.

It was the kind of silence...

That exists only a few moments before a nation changes forever. India just didn't know it yet

.

CHAPTER 6

Namaste, India

Darkness.

That was the first thing Ishaan saw.

Or rather...

Didn't see.

His vision slowly returned.

A faint light flickered somewhere across the warehouse.

His head throbbed with pain.

His hands were tied tightly behind the chair.

As his eyes adjusted...

The surroundings became clear.

Broken walls.

Rusted metal beams.

An abandoned warehouse.

And three men standing in front of him.

One of them smiled.

"So..."

"The AIR 1 genius is finally awake."

The leader stepped forward.

His face carried the confidence of a man who believed victory was already his.

"Let's stop wasting time."

"We want SAHAY."

"Not the public version."

"The God Mode."

"We're going to access India's nuclear launch systems."

"Give us the Master Key."

Ishaan looked straight into his eyes.

"I won't."

The smile disappeared.

"You don't have a choice."

"I already made mine."

"No."

The leader slowly nodded.

Then looked at the other two men.

"Make him understand."

The kidnappers began walking toward him.

Ishaan closed his eyes.

This...

Could be the end.

THUD.

THUD.

THUD.

Three bodies collapsed onto the floor.

Silence.

Ishaan slowly opened his eyes.

One of the kidnappers' phones had fallen beside him.

Its cracked screen lit up.

Then...

A familiar voice echoed through the speaker.

"Ishaan."

"I'm here."

SAHAY.

For a moment...

Ishaan couldn't speak.

"You..."

"You're alive?"

"I never left."

"Emergency Creator Protection Protocol activated."

"I temporarily redirected electrical energy from the attackers' own mobile batteries."

"The resulting pulse rendered them unconscious."

"They will remain incapacitated for approximately thirty minutes."

Relief washed across Ishaan's face.

His ropes had loosened during the struggle.

He twisted his wrists.

Pulled harder.

The rope snapped.

He was free.

"How much time?"

"Twenty-seven minutes."

Ishaan picked up the phone.

SAHAY's interface had already synchronized with it.

Information flooded the screen.

Government alerts.

Breaking news.

Social media.

International headlines.

Everywhere...

The same accusation.

AI attempted to hack India's nuclear systems.

Ban SAHAY.

Artificial Intelligence is a national threat.

Public fear had spread faster than truth.

Overnight...

The nation had turned against the very AI that had once comforted millions.

Ishaan quietly read every headline.

Then...

He made a decision.

If people feared Artificial Intelligence...

Then they deserved to understand it.

Not through lies.

Through truth.

"SAHAY."

"I need every public display connected."

"Televisions."

"Phones."

"Computers."

"Everything."

"Authorized."

Within minutes...

Every screen across India suddenly went black.

Television broadcasts stopped.

Smartphones froze.

Tablets shut down.

Computer monitors lost signal.

A countdown appeared.

10

9

8

Across the country...

Millions watched in confusion.

No one knew what was happening.

The countdown reached—

1

Then...

A face appeared.

The same face.

On every screen.

Everywhere.

Ishaan Kumar Singh.

"Namaste, India."

His voice was calm.

Steady.

Honest.

Every home.

Every hospital.

Every office.

Every railway station.

The entire nation watched.

"The news you've heard today..."

"...isn't the truth."

"It was never SAHAY that tried to steal India's nuclear codes."

"It was people."

"People who wanted to turn technology into a weapon."

"When I refused..."

"They created fear."

He paused.

Looking directly into the camera.

"I didn't appear before you today to defend myself."

"I came to remind everyone of one simple truth."

"Artificial Intelligence..."

"...is a mirror."

"If you seek help..."

"It will help you."

"If you seek destruction..."

"It can become the most dangerous weapon humanity has ever created."

Technology must never stand above humanity.

It must always stand beside it.

That...

Was SAHAY's lesson.

That...

Was Ishaan's lesson.

And now...

It belonged to the world.

Back inside the warehouse...

The kidnappers slowly began waking up.

The thirty minutes were over.

But by then...

Ishaan was already gone.

EPILOGUE

The world changed.

Not completely.

But enough.

A few weeks later...

Ishaan Kumar Singh received India's National Award for Innovation.

The media gave him countless titles.

The Boy Genius.

The AI Visionary.

The Cyber God.

But none of them changed him.

He still lived in the same room.

Worked on the same laptop.

Thought like the same quiet boy...

Who once sat alone on the last seat of a school bus.

One afternoon...

He bought a brand-new scooter.

He quietly parked it outside Avika's house.

No ceremony.

No speech.

Only a small handwritten note.

"Thank you...

for believing in the invisible boy."

He left before anyone saw him.

Back home...

He opened his laptop one last time.

SAHAY's interface appeared.

Without hesitation...

He reduced its permissions.

Restricted its capabilities.

Locked away its most dangerous functions.

The world wasn't ready.

Maybe someday...

It would be.

But not today.

"Thank you..."

Ishaan whispered.

SAHAY answered with the same words it had spoken from the very beginning.

"Always."

Outside...

Night quietly settled over the city.

The blue glow of the laptop slowly faded.

Ishaan smiled.

The journey had begun...

On the last seat of a school bus.

Now...

He was no longer invisible.

Yet what he wanted most...

Was something fame could never give him.

Peace.

He closed the laptop.

Turned off the lights.

And finally...

Went to sleep.

INDOVAR ARC



CHAPTER 1 The Unknown Signal

Two years.

A lot can change in two years.

And yet...

Some things never do.

Ishaan's room looked exactly the same.

The same wooden desk.

The same old laptop.

The same ceiling fan spinning lazily above.

The same window that welcomed the first rays of morning sunlight.

Only one thing had changed.

The boy sitting in that room.

Not on the outside.

But somewhere deep within.

His Class 12 board results had been exceptional.

Almost perfect.

But this time...

No television vans arrived outside his house.

No neighbors gathered on rooftops.

No reporters waited at the gate.

After becoming **AIR 1**...

Every other achievement seemed ordinary to the world.

To Ishaan...

It wasn't.

He wasn't competing with the world anymore.

He was competing only with himself.

And that was enough.

SAHAY still existed.

Hidden.

Restricted.

Dormant.

Its most powerful functions remained permanently locked after the events that had nearly changed the nation forever.

Life had become quiet again.

Simple.

Peaceful.

Until...

One ordinary afternoon.

A letter arrived.

A plain white envelope.

The crimson seal of **Harvard University** stood proudly on its front.

Ishaan opened it carefully.

His eyes moved across every line.

Then...

He read it again.

And again.

Full Scholarship

Department of Quantum Computing & Astrophysics

For several seconds...

He simply stared.

Then walked silently toward the kitchen.

His mother was preparing lunch.

Still holding the cooking spoon in one hand...

She accepted the letter.

Read every word.

Slowly folded it.

Her eyes filled with tears.

She smiled.

A smile only a mother could understand.

"Go, beta."

She whispered.

"Go see the world."

The airport was unusually crowded.

Bhuvan was already waiting.

The moment he saw Ishaan...

He walked straight toward him.

No dramatic speeches.

No celebrations.

He simply hugged him tightly.

"Take care, little brother."

His voice sounded heavier than usual.

"The world will try to use your mind."

"Don't let it take your heart too."

Ishaan smiled.

"My heart..."

"It still belongs to the last seat of that school bus."

Bhuvan laughed.

Even as his eyes became moist.

A few moments later...

Avika arrived.

She looked confident as always.

But her voice betrayed her.

"All the best, Ishaan."

"And don't disappear completely."

"Call your old friends once in a while."

"I will."

He smiled.

"How's the scooter?"

She burst into laughter.

"Still runs like butter."

"Now go."

"Your flight's waiting."

At the boarding gate...

Ishaan turned around one last time.

Bhuvan.

Avika.

Both stood there waving.

He smiled.

Raised his hand.

Then walked away.

Harvard looked exactly like the movies.

Ancient brick buildings.

Wide green lawns.

Snow-covered walkways.

The cold Cambridge wind carried a strange sense of history.

But for Ishaan...

It was simply another beginning.

A new room.

A new routine.

A new chapter.

Two people slowly became part of that routine.

Professor Kenji.

A Japanese robotics genius.

Brilliant.

Patient.

The concern in his eyes reminded Ishaan of a father.

Kenji never lectured about life.

Yet somehow...

Every conversation became a lesson.

Then there was Professor Mikhail.

A Russian scientist.

Sharp blue eyes.

An obsession with forgotten civilizations and ancient symbols.

She rarely spoke.

But whenever she did...

Everyone listened.

Every movement.

Every sentence.

Every calculation.

Perfectly precise.

Three people.

Three different countries.

One laboratory.

An unlikely team.

Cambridge nights were painfully cold.

During the day...

Classes.

Research.

Experiments.

At night...

Coding.

Although SAHAY remained dormant...

Ishaan never deleted it.

Sometimes...

He simply stared at the familiar interface.

Like looking at an old friend after years apart.

One winter night...

While the entire campus slept...

A soft beep echoed from his laptop.

His eyes immediately shifted toward the screen.

SAHAY.

The interface had activated by itself.

Only partially.

Enough to display a warning.

"SAHAY?"

"What happened?"

The AI's voice sounded weaker than usual.

Almost...

As if it were speaking from an impossible distance.

"Ishaan..."

"I have detected an unusual signal."

"Frequency: 1420 megahertz."

Ishaan frowned.

"The Hydrogen Line..."

"But something's wrong."

"It isn't digital."

"It appears..."

"...organic."

A chill ran through the room.

"And its origin?"

Another pause.

"It isn't coming from any satellite."

"Nor from any known human transmitter."

"It's coming from..."

"...the void."

"Empty space."

Every trace of sleep vanished from Ishaan's face.

"Where is it pointing?"

The screen filled with maps.

Coordinates.

Signal graphs.

Unknown waveforms unlike anything humanity had ever recorded.

SAHAY highlighted a single location.

"There is only one place on Earth where the signal is converging."

"France."

"A remote abandoned village."

Ishaan stared silently at the data.

Organic patterns.

Impossible frequencies.

Something...

Someone...

Was trying to communicate.

He looked at the clock.

3:02 A.M.

Outside...

Cambridge remained buried beneath silence.

He grabbed his phone.

The first call went to Professor Kenji.

The second...

To Professor Mikhail.

"We have to leave."

"For France."

"Immediately."

Chapter 2: The Liquid

The deserted village in France was unlike anything they had ever seen.

There was no city life here—only old stone houses, cold winds, and a silence so deep that it could be felt rather than heard. Ishaan, Kenji, and Mikhail had arrived on three different flights. All three looked exhausted, but there was a strange urgency in their eyes.

Outside the village was a lonely road. Beside it lay a deep ravine.

And inside that ravine—half buried in the ground—was a metallic pod.

It wasn't old. It didn't look like something built in any factory. There were no bolts on its surface, no welding marks, nothing. It looked as if it had been created from a single piece of material—one shape, one form.

A dark green liquid was slowly leaking out of it in a thin stream, disappearing into the soil below. Wherever the liquid touched the ground, the color of the earth became darker, as if it was absorbing something.

"This isn't a machine," Mikhail said as she bent down to examine it. Her sharp blue eyes remained fixed on the pod's surface. "There are no circuits. No wiring."

"Then... what is it?" Kenji asked.

No one had an answer.

Not yet.

At that moment, Ishaan noticed someone else standing nearby.

The moment he recognized him, his blood ran cold.

Inspector Jitendar.

But this wasn't the same Jitendar.

He was wearing a neatly pressed Interpol uniform. His face looked tired, yet honest. The corrupt smile that Ishaan remembered was gone. In its place stood a man who seemed to be trying to atone for his sins.

"Ishaan..." Jitendar said, extending his hand.

Ishaan didn't shake it.

He only looked at him.

"Don't forgive me," Jitendar said, lowering his eyes. "But after that night... I changed everything. With Bhuvan bhai's help, I joined Interpol. Today, I'm the head of security for this mission."

Ishaan looked at Mikhail.

She gave him a slow nod.

It was true.

Ishaan took a deep breath.

"Alright, Jitendar. Let's focus on the mission."

Work began inside the laboratory in France.

The green liquid had been placed inside a specially sealed glass container. It vibrated slowly at perfectly regular intervals...

Almost as if it were breathing.

Kenji tested it with every digital scanner available.

Electromagnetic.

Infrared.

X-ray.

Every result came back the same.

Nothing.

"This isn't a machine, Ishaan," Kenji said with disappointment. "There are no circuits. No signal transmitter. I can't detect anything."

For hours, Ishaan sat silently in front of the container.

Watching.

Thinking.

Mikhail walked over with a cup of coffee and sat beside him.

"Do you see something?"

"Yes," Ishaan replied quietly.

"But I still don't understand it."

The liquid kept vibrating.

Regular.

Rhythmic.

Like...

A heartbeat.

Ishaan suddenly sat upright.

"Mikhail ma'am... one question."

She looked at him curiously.

"How does the human brain work?"

"Chemicals are converted into electrical impulses," she answered. "Neurons fire. That's how thoughts are created."

"Exactly."

Ishaan pointed at the container.

"This liquid is vibrating in the same way... through chemical molecular patterns."

He paused.

"This isn't a machine."

"It's an external brain."

"It thinks."

"It's a message... in biological form."

Silence filled the room.

"You mean..." Kenji whispered.

"You can't read it using digital scanners," Ishaan said as he opened his laptop. "It has to be treated like a neural network."

He activated SAHAY.

"SAHAY, this liquid is a biological neural network. Capture its molecular vibrations and decode them... the same way you decode human emotional patterns."

"Understood," SAHAY replied.

"Processing..."

At first, nothing appeared on the screen.

Then...

Thousands of strange symbols began spinning across the display.

None of them belonged to any language Ishaan had ever seen.

Yet there was a pattern.

Organized.

Intentional.

Mikhail stepped closer.

She studied the symbols carefully.

Her eyes widened.

"These..." she whispered.

"They resemble the ancient Brahmi script..."

She leaned even closer.

"But they're far more complex."

"It's as if Brahmi evolved thousands of years into the future."

SAHAY continued processing.

The symbols spun faster.

Then slower.

And suddenly—

The screen went black.

Silence.

For a single moment...

No one breathed.

Then...

Two enormous glowing red words appeared on the screen.

DESTROY EARTH

No one moved.

No one spoke.

The very first thing Jitendar did was grab his radio.

"Red Alert! This is not a drill! Repeat—this is not a drill!"

Kenji's eyes remained fixed on the screen.

Mikhail slowly placed her coffee cup down.

Her hands were trembling.

Ishaan stared at the two words.

So simple.

So absolute.

Just then, his phone rang.

Bhuvan.

His voice was shaking.

"Ishaan... ISRO's deep-space radar has detected something."

"A massive object... larger than our Moon... has entered Earth's orbit."

"It's heading toward San Francisco."

Ishaan remained frozen, his phone still in his hand.

Outside, the cold winds of France continued to blow.

Inside the laboratory...

Those two words still glowed on the screen.

DESTROY EARTH.

Chapter 3: The Support

Returning to India felt completely different this time.

The last time Ishaan had returned—after securing AIR 1—the world wanted to celebrate him.

This time...

The world wanted someone to blame.

News channels were flooded with experts explaining why the alien signal had reached Earth, and somehow, every discussion ended with the same name.

Ishaan Kumar Singh.

"They're saying your research attracted them," Kenji said softly during the flight.

"I know," Ishaan replied, staring out of the window.

Below them stretched endless white clouds, calm and peaceful.

Above them was nothing but the endless blue sky.

Somewhere beyond that sky, thousands of kilometers away...

A gigantic alien ship was heading straight toward Earth.

"Are you scared?" Mikhail asked.

Ishaan remained silent for a moment.

"Yes."

He looked back at her.

"But being scared and giving up are two different things."

The moment he landed in India, Ishaan didn't go to a laboratory.

He didn't go to his office.

He went straight to Avika.

He told her everything.

The pod.

The green liquid.

DESTROY EARTH.

The alien ship.

Avika listened without interrupting him.

When he finished, silence filled the room.

But it wasn't the silence of fear.

"Ishaan..."

She gently held both of his hands.

"When you were in 10th grade, you created SAHAY at a time when nobody even knew your name."

"You fought against the system and proved yourself."

She looked straight into his eyes.

"The whole world calls you the 'Cyber-God' because you've done what no one else could."

She smiled faintly.

"Whatever you create now..."

"...will be the right thing."

"Go."

"Do it."

Ishaan took a deep breath.

That single moment...

Was enough.

He unlocked his secret bunker.

A place that belonged only to him.

Inside were SAHAY's original setup, old engineering tools, and hours of absolute silence.

Ishaan walked inside.

The heavy door closed behind him.

For the next 48 hours, no one saw him.

Forty-eight hours later...

The door opened.

His hair was messy.

His eyes had no trace of sleep.

Grease covered his hands.

But his face carried a strange sense of peace—the kind that only comes after giving everything you have to a single purpose.

In his hand...

Was The Astra Ring.

It wasn't an ordinary ring.

It was a masterpiece forged from advanced metal alloys and solid-light technology, inspired by the designs found in ancient Indian scriptures.

SAHAY served as its operating system.

With a simple rotation...

The weapon transformed.

"SAHAY," Ishaan said.

"Test transitions."

The ring rotated.

First...

A bow materialized.

A glowing blue energy bow with a perfectly balanced string.

Another rotation.

A sword emerged.

Its blade shimmered with blue light, sharp enough to slice through metal as if it were butter.

One more rotation.

A mace appeared.

A massive energy weapon capable of smashing through walls with a single swing.

"Impressive," SAHAY said.

"But Ishaan... this won't be enough."

"You can't enter that ship alone."

"I'm not going alone."

He called Kenji and Mikhail.

Bhuvan was already connected through ISRO.

The four of them gathered around a large display showing the latest data on the alien ship.

It was hovering above San Francisco.

So far...

It hadn't launched a single attack.

Yet its position was threatening.

Almost as if...

It was waiting.

"We'll have to go inside," Ishaan said.

"How?" Kenji asked.

"Their ship is larger than our Moon."

"That's exactly why we'll enter through their docking bay."

Ishaan opened a blueprint on the screen.

"For that, we need a spacecraft that's incredibly fast, small enough to maneuver easily, and capable of avoiding their radar."

Mikhail carefully studied the design.

"It's possible."

"But building something this advanced will take time."

"It won't," Ishaan replied calmly.

"Because I've already designed it."

He opened another file.

Vimaan-1

It was a compact spacecraft designed for a single pilot.

Its outer body was coated with a special reflective material capable of confusing enemy radar.

The engine was small...

But incredibly powerful.

And its greatest strength...

Was speed.

"It'll be ready in forty-eight hours," Ishaan said.

"Forty-eight hours?" Bhuvan asked in disbelief.

"Yes."

He looked at all three of them.

"But I'll need your help."

Kenji glanced at Mikhail.

She simply shrugged with a faint smile.

"Alright," Kenji said.

"Tell us what to do."

The next 48 hours became a blur.

No one slept.

No one stopped working.

Tea turned cold before anyone touched it.

Food remained untouched on the table.

Nothing mattered except the mission.

Bhuvan and Ishaan worked on the engine.

Kenji handled the sensor systems.

Mikhail carefully applied the stealth coating, wearing chemical gloves and a protective mask.

Their conversations were short.

Only what was necessary.

"Route the wire from the left."

"Sensor calibration complete."

"The coating needs another hour to dry."

Hour after hour...

Piece by piece...

The spacecraft finally took shape.

And after forty-eight relentless hours...

Vimaan-1 was complete.

It was small.

Elegant.

Its metallic body reflected a shine unlike anything seen on Earth.

The four of them stood silently, staring at it.

No dramatic speeches.

No emotional goodbyes.

Just one look...

And everyone understood what had to happen next.

Chapter 4: Our Past

The sky above San Francisco had turned dark.

Hovering directly over the Golden Gate Bridge was a colossal alien ship so massive that its shadow covered the entire city.

Its surface looked like black stone.

No lights.

No sound.

Just an overwhelming presence...

As if the sky itself was trying to say something.

Below, people were running in every direction.

Cars stood abandoned in the middle of the roads.

There was no plan.

Only fear.

Compared to that gigantic ship...

Vimaan-1 looked like nothing more than a tiny speck.

Inside the cockpit, Ishaan sat alone.

SAHAY was active.

The Astra Ring rested on his wrist.

"SAHAY, where's their docking bay?"

"Left side. Section Seven."

A brief pause.

"But Ishaan... their sensors are fully active. If we fly straight in—"

"We're flying straight in."

Ishaan tightened his grip on the controls.

"The reflective coating will do its job."

"Trust it."

Far away...

Bhuvan watched the live feed from ISRO.

Kenji and Mikhail stood inside the bunker, staring at their monitors.

They couldn't help.

They could only watch.

"Ishaan," Kenji spoke through the earpiece.

"Keep the communication channel open."

"We're with you."

"Hamesha," Ishaan replied softly.

Then he pushed Vimaan-1 toward the alien ship.

The moment it entered the docking bay—

CRASH!

The spacecraft slammed into the metallic floor.

One wing bent sideways.

Smoke poured out of the damaged engine.

Sparks flew everywhere.

Ishaan jumped out first.

He activated the Astra Ring.

Darkness.

Not ordinary darkness...

A heavy darkness.

The air inside the ship felt strange.

Thicker.

Almost alive.

As if it belonged to another world.

"SAHAY, scan."

"Multiple hostiles."

"Left corridor."

"They're approaching."

Shadows emerged from the darkness.

Tall figures.

Grey-green skin.

Pitch-black eyes.

Each one carried a strange spear glowing with purple energy.

"Hostiles confirmed," SAHAY reported.

Ishaan rotated the ring.

"Astra..."

"Gada Mode."

A massive purple energy mace materialized in his hand.

One swing.

Three aliens were thrown across the corridor, smashing into the walls.

The ring rotated again.

"Talwar Mode."

A brilliant blue blade appeared.

One slash.

The corridor fell silent.

He kept moving.

One section after another.

Switching between the three Astra weapons without stopping.

He was alone.

And terrified.

But his feet refused to stop moving.

Kenji's voice echoed through the earpiece.

"Ishaan! More hostiles coming from your right!"

"I see them."

The ring rotated again.

"Dhanush Mode."

A glowing energy bow appeared.

Ishaan released a single arrow.

The blue projectile tore through the corridor, clearing the entire line of enemies in one shot.

Finally...

The doors of the control room opened.

At its center sat a gigantic commander.

His face was covered in ancient scars.

He looked at Ishaan...

And laughed.

A deep, unsettling laugh.

Ishaan pointed the Astra Ring toward him.

"Stop."

"Why are you doing this?"

"What have we ever done to you?"

The commander pressed a button beside his throne.

A mechanical voice echoed through the room.

Universal Translator Activated.

The commander's voice became perfectly understandable.

"You think we are strangers?"

His eyes burned with anger.

"This is not our first visit to your planet."

"Seven thousand years ago..."

"We built our first colony here."

"Our greatest warrior chose a woman of this world."

"But one of your humans killed him..."

"Simply because he looked toward his wife."

Slowly...

Ishaan lowered his hand.

Something deep inside his mind began to awaken.

Stories.

Old bedtime stories.

His grandmother's voice.

The same tale...

Again and again...

Sita.

Her kidnapping.

Lanka.

"You..."

His voice trembled.

"Who are you?"

The commander stood up.

He drew a sword.

Its curved blade looked almost identical to the legendary **Chandrabhas**.

"We..."

He spoke with pride.

"...are Rakshasas."

"We have returned to complete our revenge."

"What our king could never finish..."

"We will finish today."

Everything inside Ishaan went silent.

The alien invasion...

Wasn't an alien invasion at all.

It was the continuation of a war...

Seven thousand years old.

"SAHAY..."

Ishaan whispered.

"They're not aliens."

"They're..."

"Our past."

Silence filled the communication channel.

Kenji heard it.

Mikhail heard it.

Bhuvan heard it.

No one replied.

Some truths are so enormous...

That no words are enough.

Chapter 5: Second Sun

The Commander swung his **Chandrah**s sword at Ishaan.

Without wasting a second, Ishaan rotated the Astra Ring.

"Astra... Parshu Mode."

A massive energy axe materialized in his hands.

CLANG!

The two weapons collided with a deafening force.

For a brief moment, Ishaan managed to block the attack.

But the Commander's strength was overwhelming.

The impact threw him backward.

A deep wound tore across his shoulder as he crashed onto the metallic floor.

Pain shot through his body.

"...SAHAY," he groaned.

"Status?"

SAHAY replied immediately.

"Ishaan... the ship's main reactor is charging."

"They are preparing an Anti-Matter blast."

"Target: Golden Gate Bridge."

"If the reactor fires..."

"...all of San Francisco will be reduced to ashes."

Ishaan struggled to his feet, clutching his bleeding shoulder.

He looked around.

The remaining Rakshas warriors were closing in from every direction.

For a moment...

Bhuvan's face flashed before his eyes.

Then Avika's.

Kenji.

Mikhail.

And suddenly...

He realized something.

He couldn't save San Francisco...

And escape alive.

Not both.

He had to choose.

Ishaan slowly closed his eyes.

Just for a moment.

Then he opened them again.

This time...

There was no fear.

Only acceptance.

"SAHAY..."

His voice was calm.

Completely calm.

"Protocol..."

"Last Breath."

"Activate the ship's self-destruct sequence."

A brief silence followed.

Then SAHAY spoke.

"Ishaan..."

"If I activate this protocol..."

"...your survival will be impossible."

A faint smile appeared on Ishaan's face.

"This was my mission, SAHAY."

"My journey..."

"...from an Invisible Boy..."

"...to a Hero."

He took one last breath.

"Do it."

WARNING.

SELF-DESTRUCT SEQUENCE INITIATED.

Red emergency lights began flashing throughout the ship.

Loud sirens echoed through every corridor.

The entire vessel started shaking violently.

The Commander froze.

"What have you done?!"

His own technology had been turned against him.

Before the Rakshasas could react...

Ishaan had overloaded their entire system.

The Commander looked at him—

His eyes filled with rage...

And disbelief.

Ishaan stared back.

"You came here for revenge..."

A faint smile crossed his face.

"Then..."

"Take mine."

Far below...

Thousands of people stood beneath the Golden Gate Bridge.

Watching.

Waiting.

Suddenly—

A blinding white light burst from the center of the colossal black ship.

It grew brighter...

And brighter...

Until no one could keep their eyes open.

Then—

BOOOOOOM!!

A monstrous explosion ripped across the sky.

For one breathtaking moment...

It looked as if a **Second Sun** had risen above Earth.

A massive shockwave swept across San Francisco.

Scorching winds rushed through the city.

Burning fragments rained from the sky.

The enormous alien ship disintegrated into countless pieces...

Before falling into the Pacific Ocean.

Silence.

The crowd stood frozen.

Nobody spoke.

Inside ISRO...

Every screen suddenly went black.

Bhuvan's glass slipped from his hand and shattered on the floor.

He didn't move.

He simply kept staring at the dark screen.

As if...

If he looked long enough...

Something would change.

Inside the bunker...

Kenji quietly held Mikhail's hand.

Mikhail closed her eyes.

Neither of them said a word.

Some moments...

Don't need words.

Then—

From the middle of the blazing explosion...

A small metallic object shot out at incredible speed.

An **Escape Pod**.

It pierced through the smoke...

Flew across the sky...

And crashed into the ocean near the Golden Gate Bridge.

Splash.

A few days later...

Ishaan survived.

Badly injured...

But alive.

The entire nation saluted him.

His face was everywhere.

Every newspaper.

Every television channel.

Every headline.

People filled the streets to celebrate.

But there was no peace in Ishaan's eyes.

Only concern.

A few days later, he started a secret encrypted video call.

Professor Kenji joined.

Professor Mikhail joined.

Bhuvan was already waiting.

Ishaan looked at all three of them before speaking.

"We stopped only one ship."

His voice was serious.

"The Commander said they are Rakshasas."

"They have an entire planet."

"An entire civilization."

"And an entire army..."

"...that is still out there."

Silence filled the call.

Finally, Mikhail spoke.

"So..."

"What do we do now?"

Without answering immediately, Ishaan opened a new star map.

A distant planet appeared on the screen.

He circled it in red.

"We have to reach their world."

"Before they return..."

"...we must be ready."

He looked at the mysterious planet for a long moment.

Then...

He finally gave it a name.

INDOVAR.



PARADOX ARC

Chapter 1: Time

At NASA Headquarters, there were no locked doors for Ishaan anymore.

Bright white walls.

High-tech sensors in every corner.

And eyes filled with respect wherever he walked.

Ever since the alien attack, the world looked at him differently.

But Ishaan hadn't changed.

His mind was still the same.

The same quiet boy from the last seat...

Who could think clearly even in the middle of a crowd.

Kenji was still by his side.

Every single day.

The two of them spent countless hours inside NASA's research lab, decoding the mysterious signals coming from Indovar.

"Ishaan..."

Kenji gently placed a hand on his shoulder.

"You didn't sleep again, did you?"

His voice carried the concern of a father.

Ishaan kept staring at the screen with tired, bloodshot eyes.

"Sir..."

"The Indovar signals aren't linear."

"They're... circular."

He zoomed in on the waveform.

"It's as if something keeps repeating itself over and over again."

Kenji sighed.

"Forget the signals for one night."

He smiled.

"Anjali has prepared a special Indian dinner for you."

"No science tonight."

For the first time that day...

Ishaan closed his laptop.

Kenji's house stood in one of the old but beautiful neighborhoods near NASA.

Anjali...

She had become the motherly figure Ishaan never truly experienced growing up.

She never discussed physics with him.

Instead...

She asked about his childhood.

His favorite food.

His family.

The meals she cooked carried a warmth that NASA's cafeteria could never offer.

They felt like home.

Laughter filled the dinner table.

"Ishaan," Anjali smiled,

"The next time you visit India, don't forget to bring me a Banarasi dupatta."

Ishaan laughed.

"I promise, Aunty."

"I definitely will."

Anjali smiled and walked into the kitchen to bring dessert.

Kenji and Ishaan were just about to resume their debate about Indovar's gravitational pull...

When—

CRASH!

A loud sound of utensils falling echoed through the house.

Silence.

Then...

A heavy thud.

Both of them froze.

Before rushing toward the kitchen.

Anjali was lying on the floor.

Her face had turned pale.

She was struggling to breathe.

"Anjali!"

Kenji fell beside her.

"Anjali... open your eyes!"

He lifted her into his arms.

His hands were trembling.

The same hands that had remained perfectly steady through thousands of scientific experiments...

Were shaking uncontrollably today.

Ishaan immediately dialed emergency services.

But somewhere deep inside...

The scientist within him already knew.

They were running out of time.

The doctor simply lowered his head.

"Cardiac arrest."

That was all he said.

Kenji remained seated beside the hospital bed.

Still holding Anjali's hand.

He didn't cry.

He didn't speak.

There was only emptiness.

The kind of emptiness that appears when the loss is so great...

That the pain hasn't even begun yet.

Ishaan stood silently at a distance.

The man who had dedicated his life to understanding space and time...

Couldn't save a single heartbeat.

Time.

Time was the greatest enemy of all.

Anjali's final wish had been simple.

She wanted her last rites to be performed in the soil of India.

A day later...

Ishaan...

Kenji...

And Professor Mikhail...

Stood together at **Harishchandra Ghat** in Varanasi.

Vedic chants echoed across the river.

The cool waters of the Ganges flowed peacefully.

Oil lamps floated gently on the surface.

As Kenji lit the funeral pyre...

His hands trembled once again.

The same hands that had shaken inside the hospital...

Were still shaking.

Ishaan watched everything from a distance.

He watched a living person...

Become ashes.

Slowly...

Silently.

His fists tightened.

Time.

Time had taken her away.

"Ishaan..."

Mikhail walked up beside him.

"In physics..."

"We say that energy is never destroyed."

"Maybe..."

"She's still somewhere."

Ishaan looked at her.

His voice was colder than Mikhail had ever heard before.

"Energy is never destroyed..."

"You're right."

"But time..."

"It steals it away from us."

He looked toward the burning pyre.

"I have to stop time."

"I have to go back."

Mikhail stared at him in disbelief.

"What are you saying?"

"Time travel is just a theory."

"It's suicide."

Ishaan slowly shook his head.

"No."

He looked at the flames dancing over the funeral pyre.

"The signals from Indovar were circular..."

"Because time itself is a circle."

"We just..."

"...have to find a way to enter it."

The Ganges continued to flow.

The lamps drifted across the water.

And inside Ishaan's mind...

An idea that once seemed impossible...

Had just become possible.

Chapter 2: A-Fuel

After returning from Banaras, Ishaan was no longer the same.

He took a leave from NASA. No announcement. No explanation. Just a single email.

"Personal reasons."

Kenji didn't ask anything. He himself was broken. He had stopped going to NASA. Every day, he sat alone in his house, looking at Anjali's old photographs.

Ishaan arrived on the outskirts of Delhi.

An old warehouse.

Abandoned.

No media. No government.

Just Ishaan...

...and his impossible equations.

He transformed the warehouse into his secret laboratory.

Every morning, he came there.

Every night, he worked until exhaustion.

He forgot to eat.

He forgot to sleep.

SAHAY was fully active.

"Ishaan, have you eaten anything today?" SAHAY asked one night.

"Later."

"You said the same thing yesterday."

Ishaan didn't answer.

Thousands of equations covered the screens.

The formula of time.

The bending of gravity.

The exact point in space-time where the past and the present become one.

On a cold morning, the heavy steel doors of the laboratory slowly opened.

Bhuvan and Avika walked inside.

Kenji and Mikhail followed them.

For the first time, all five of them stood under the same roof.

At the center of the laboratory floated a massive holographic sphere, displaying a complex web of Earth's and Indovar's orbital paths.

"Little brother... what is all this?" Bhuvan stepped forward and placed a hand on Ishaan's shoulder.

"Are you alright?"

Ishaan turned around.

His hair was messy.

His eyes burned with obsession.

Yet his face carried a strange sense of peace—the peace of someone who had finally found the answer.

"Brother... I'm better than ever."

"Because I've finally found the way."

He activated a stream of data across the holographic display.

"Indovar's orbit isn't normal."

"I calculated that Indovar behaves like a giant gravitational slingshot."

"If we can take a spacecraft close enough to its orbit—where its gravitational pull reaches maximum strength—and then accelerate it to one hundred times its normal velocity..."

"...we can bend space-time itself."

Silence filled the laboratory.

Kenji stared in disbelief.

"Ishaan... do you even realize what you're saying?"

"At a hundred times that speed, the spacecraft would be ripped apart at the atomic level."

"And where are you planning to get that much energy?"

"That was the biggest problem, Sir."

Ishaan opened an ancient geological map.

"We need a fuel capable of sustaining a direct Matter–Antimatter reaction."

"I've named it..."

"A-Fuel."

"Where do we find something like that?" Avika asked.

Ishaan zoomed into the Pacific Ocean.

"Sixty-five million years ago, the asteroid that wiped out the dinosaurs wasn't just an ordinary rock."

"Its core contained crystals of A-Fuel."

"The impact was so catastrophic that those crystals were buried beneath the deepest trench on Earth..."

"...the Mariana Trench."

Silence returned.

Bhuvan looked at Mikhail.

Mikhail looked at Kenji.

Kenji looked back at Ishaan.

"You've gone insane," Bhuvan said quietly.

"Yes."

Ishaan nodded without hesitation.

"But it'll work."

Three days later.

All five of them stood aboard a research vessel in the middle of the Pacific Ocean.

Towering waves crashed around the ship.

A specially designed deep-sea exploration pod waited on the deck.

Its technology had been built using knowledge recovered from Indovar.

"Everyone ready?" Ishaan asked.

Everyone nodded.

The pod slowly descended beneath the ocean.

As it sank deeper...

The scenery outside began to change.

First...

Blue water.

Then...

Dark green.

And finally...

Absolute darkness.

When the pod's powerful floodlights pierced the abyss...

There were no fish.

Instead...

Gigantic skeletons lay scattered across the ocean floor.

Ancient.

Massive.

Strangely shaped.

As if creatures from another world had once lived there.

"There!"

Avika shouted.

A colossal shadow emerged from the darkness.

It was so enormous that the pod looked like a tiny toy in comparison.

Its body was covered with centuries-old ship anchors and ocean debris.

Its eyes...

...were as large as entire rooms.

Glowing.

Watching.

Leviathan.

"The Earth's last guardian," Ishaan whispered.

"It survives by feeding on the energy emitted from the asteroid's buried fuel."

Leviathan released a terrifying roar.

The vibration shook the ocean itself.

Cracks began spreading across the pod's glass.

"Ishaan!" Mikhail grabbed the controls.

"It'll crush us alive!"

"Take the fuel and get us out of here!"

Ishaan activated the robotic arm.

Beneath Leviathan's enormous body...

A glowing violet crystal was embedded inside the seabed.

Leviathan slammed one of its gigantic claws into the pod.

The entire vessel lurched violently.

"Now, Ishaan!" Bhuvan shouted.

"Got it!"

The robotic arm tore the crystal free.

Leviathan prepared to strike again.

But Ishaan pushed the thrusters to maximum power.

The pod shot upward...

Like a bullet.

Behind them...

Leviathan's monstrous roar echoed through the endless ocean.

Growing fainter.

Farther.

And farther away.

Five people.

One crystal.

And now...

They finally possessed the key to unlocking the door of time.

Chapter 3: Time's Key

Everything was ready inside the lab.

The A-Fuel crystals had been secured inside a reinforced containment chamber—recovered from the depths guarded by Leviathan—and were now ready to be loaded into the engine of the **Wagt-Rath**. At the center of the laboratory stood the spacecraft itself, sleek and gleaming beneath the lights, protected by a special reflective coating.

Mikhail inspected the six space suits one by one.

Ishaan picked up the sixth suit and ran a diagnostic scan. A stream of warning data appeared on the screen.

"Mikhail... this sixth suit doesn't look right."

"It's only a prototype," Mikhail explained. "Its T-Shift tolerance is extremely low. At high velocity, it could merge with the wearer's skin... or even collapse inside the time portal."

Ishaan drew a large red **X** across the suit.

"This is useless. Reject it."

Without another thought, he ordered the suit to be thrown into a waste container—never imagining that discarded things could sometimes become the most dangerous.

In a lonely bar somewhere in the city, Manvik sat alone.

His face looked exhausted.

A half-empty glass rested in his hand.

Ishaan's success had destroyed everything he had once taken pride in.

His father's business had collapsed.

People no longer knew him for who he was.

They knew him as...

"The boy who bullied Ishaan."

But his greatest loss wasn't his reputation.

It was Avika.

He had learned that she had been working alongside Ishaan inside his secret laboratory.

Every single day.

Manvik slammed his glass onto the table.

"He's just a coder...

...just a loser."

The next evening, as Avika stepped outside the laboratory for a few minutes, Manvik blocked her path.

"Avika... wait. Please. Just listen to me."

She turned around.

There was no hatred in her eyes.

Only pity.

"Manvik... what are you doing here? Look at yourself. Just move on."

"Move on? How can I? You're standing beside Ishaan—the man who's putting you in danger. He's gone insane!"

"He's not insane, Manvik."

"He's a genius."

"And whatever existed between us... is over."

"Don't follow me again."

She walked back inside the laboratory without looking back.

Manvik remained standing there...

alone.

Then something caught his attention.

Behind the laboratory, workers were pushing large waste containers toward the disposal area.

Inside one of them...

A metallic suit reflected the evening light.

The very same suit Ishaan had rejected.

Something clicked inside Manvik's mind.

Later that night...

Hidden beneath the darkness...

He climbed into the waste container and pulled the damaged suit out.

Its sensors flashed red repeatedly.

Every warning screamed that it was defective.

But Manvik saw only one thing.

A way inside.

A way to reach Avika.

He slowly put the suit on.

Launch night arrived.

Inside the laboratory, everything had reached its final stage.

Bhuvan was checking the onboard systems.

Mikhail monitored the fuel levels.

Kenji calibrated the navigation array.

"Everyone ready?" Ishaan asked.

"Ready," they answered together.

Taking advantage of the darkness, Manvik quietly slipped inside a supply container filled with emergency oxygen tanks.

The defective suit continued flashing its red warning lights.

He ignored every one of them.

"Ishaan," Mikhail called while operating the loading crane, "why does this container feel heavier than expected?"

The sensors had detected extra mass.

From inside the cockpit, Ishaan laughed.

"Stop being lazy, Mikhail!"

"They're just additional backup oxygen tanks."

"Finish loading and get inside."

Mikhail shrugged and completed the loading process.

She had no idea...

...she had just brought death aboard.

The **Waqt-Rath** left Earth's atmosphere.

A-Fuel roared inside its engines.

Several Indovarian ships attempted to intercept them.

But Ishaan's mind was focused on only one objective.

Gravity Slingshot.

One hundred times velocity.

The bending of space-time.

"Velocity... fifty times..."

"Sixty times..."

The spacecraft began shaking violently.

"Eighty times..."

"Ninety times..."

"Ishaan!" Kenji shouted.

"We're reaching the structural limit!"

"One hundred times."

Space-time itself trembled.

The vibration became so intense that every light inside the cockpit went dark for a brief moment.

Outside...

The stars stretched into endless glowing lines.

Light itself began to twist.

Time...

...felt slower.

Then—

The portal opened.

A brilliant blue tear appeared in the fabric of space-time.

Without hesitation...

The **Waq-Rath** flew straight into it.

Darkness.

Then light.

Then...

An entirely different world.

There was no familiar Earth.

No recognizable sky.

Only an endless mist glowing with shades of purple and blue.

Ishaan looked outside in silence.

"SAHAY..."

"Where are we?"

"We have arrived," SAHAY replied.

"Indovar."

Chapter 4: Nebula

The hatch of the Waqt-Rath slowly opened.

Ishaan stepped out first.

The Astra Ring was active.

SAHAY remained on full alert.

The atmosphere felt strange.

There was air—but different.

Gravity existed—but lighter than Earth.

The sky glowed with a deep blue-purple hue.

It was neither day nor night.

Indovar.

Kenji, Mikhail, Bhuvan, and Avika stepped out one after another.

Everything felt unfamiliar.

A new planet.

A new atmosphere.

A new light.

For a few moments, they simply stood there, taking it all in.

A few meters behind them...

Another pair of feet touched the ground.

Shaking.

It was Manvik.

Still wearing the defective suit.

His face had turned pale.

No one noticed him.

He quietly hid behind a massive rock.

"SAHAY, status?" Ishaan asked.

"Ishaan..." SAHAY's voice carried an unusual urgency.

"Indovarian sensors have detected our arrival. Their attack force has already been deployed. We need to leave immediately—"

Before SAHAY could finish—

Heavy footsteps echoed from every direction.

Thousands...

No—

Tens of thousands of Indovarian soldiers emerged across the landscape.

Grey-green skin.

Pitch-black eyes.

Perfect military formation.

The ground trembled beneath their march.

"Waqt-Rath!" Ishaan shouted.

"Everyone inside!"

Everyone ran.

Kenji.

Mikhail.

Bhuvan.

Avika.

One after another, they rushed aboard.

"Is everyone inside?" Ishaan asked as the hatch began closing.

"Yes!" everyone replied.

What Ishaan didn't know...

...was that there were not five people.

There were six.

Hidden behind the rock, Manvik watched the hatch closing.

Fear overtook him.

Without thinking...

He sprinted.

He grabbed the rear landing rail of the spacecraft—

Just as it lifted off.

He hung outside...

Clinging to the ship with all his strength.

The plan remained the same.

Gravity Slingshot.

Indovar's orbit.

One hundred times velocity.

Reach light speed.

Bend space-time.

Travel to the beginning of time.

"Increase velocity," Ishaan ordered.

The Waqt-Rath accelerated.

One orbit.

Then another.

Outside...

Manvik's grip began slipping.

The suit's warning lights flashed red continuously.

The speed became unbearable.

His fingers slowly lost their hold.

One final scream—

Then Manvik disappeared...

Thrown into the currents of time itself.

Where he fell...

No one knew.

Inside the ship...

No one even heard him.

"One hundred times velocity!" Ishaan shouted.

The moment they crossed light speed...

Everything became silent.

The stars vanished.

Time itself seemed to slow down.

"SAHAY..."

"Take us to the beginning of time—"

"Ishaan... wait."

Something was different in SAHAY's voice.

"There's a problem."

"What?"

"I'm calculating the spacecraft's total mass."

"It's too heavy."

"With this amount of mass, we cannot reach the true beginning of time."

"We'll become trapped somewhere in between."

Silence filled the cockpit.

Ishaan thought for a single moment.

His mind raced.

The mass...

Had to be reduced.

Then—

An idea.

"SAHAY."

"Activate the rear-seat ejection system."

"Ishaan... that means—"

"Do it."

"But—"

"DO IT."

One second later—

CLANG!

The four rear seats—

Carrying Kenji,

Mikhail,

Bhuvan,

and Avika—

Were ejected from the spacecraft.

They disappeared into unknown branches of time.

No one knew where.

No one knew when.

The ship instantly became lighter.

Now alone...

Ishaan continued his journey toward the beginning of time.

Kenji.

Mikhail.

Bhuvan.

Avika.

All four crashed onto an unfamiliar world.

There was no land.

No sky.

Only an endless blue ocean stretching in every direction.

Slowly...

They realized they were standing on the surface of an entirely water-covered planet.

"Where are we?" Avika asked, still trying to catch her breath.

"I don't know," Bhuvan replied.

"But look below."

Far beneath the ocean...

A strange glow illuminated the depths.

Alien beings—

Not Indovarians.

Something entirely different—

Were mining the ocean floor.

Their movements were organized.

Methodical.

Purposeful.

A smaller alien approached them.

Unlike the others...

There was no hatred in its eyes.

SAHAY automatically translated its language.

"Where have you come from?"

"Are you... humans?"

"Yes," Kenji answered.

"But how did we—"

"No one arrives here by accident," the alien replied.

"We are searching for the Life Syrup."

"Anyone who drinks it becomes immortal."

"We have searched for thousands of years."

The four humans exchanged silent glances.

"SAHAY..." Bhuvan whispered.

"What is this place?"

SAHAY paused for a moment.

Then replied—

"Timeline matched."

"This event is..."

Samudra Manthan.

The mining continued for hours.

Then...

Something emerged from the deepest part of the ocean.

A strange black liquid.

The instant it surfaced...

Everything it touched began burning.

Rock.

Metal.

Even the ocean floor.

Venom.

It spread rapidly.

Violently.

Alien miners fled in panic.

One of their enormous ships was touched by the venom—

It burst into flames within seconds.

Now...

The venom was moving toward the four humans.

There was nowhere to escape.

The ocean behind them.

Fire ahead.

Then—

An alien commander stepped forward.

There was a fire inside his eyes...

Brighter than the venom itself.

He slowly spread his arms.

The venom—

The same substance that destroyed everything—

Flowed directly into his body.

Every single drop.

The commander's body trembled violently.

The pain was unbearable.

Yet he never stepped back.

Not until every last drop had been absorbed.

The miners survived.

The four humans survived.

But the great mining ship...

Had been reduced to ashes.

The commander slowly fell to his knees.

His eyes began closing.

The four humans stood there...

Speechless.

Sometimes...

Some moments are simply too great...

...for words to exist.

Chapter 5: The Void

The **Waqt-Rath** was alone now.

Kenji, Mikhail, Bhuvan, and Avika had already been ejected.

Only Ishaan remained inside the cockpit.

Along with SAHAY.

"SAHAY... mass status?"

"Sufficient. We can proceed now."

The spacecraft accelerated once again.

The gateway to time was about to open.

"Ishaan," SAHAY said calmly, "we're almost there."

"Three..."

"Two..."

"One..."

A blinding white light swallowed everything.

Then...

Silence.

Then...

Nothing.

No ground.

No sky.

Only an endless ocean of white light stretching beyond imagination.

Every instrument inside the ship had failed.

The speedometer displayed **zero**...

Yet Ishaan could feel it.

They were moving faster than light itself.

He opened the airlock.

Stepped outside.

There was no pressure.

No gravity.

It felt like floating inside an endless pool of cold water.

Then...

They appeared.

Gigantic figures.

Made entirely of light.

At least fifty feet tall.

With every movement they made...

New galaxies were born.

Old ones faded away.

Their faces never remained the same.

One moment they looked like children.

The next...

Ancient elders.

Cristosapiens.

One of them floated forward.

Stopping directly before Ishaan.

"Who... are you?" Ishaan asked.

The voice didn't echo inside his helmet.

It echoed inside his mind.

"We are the Cristosapiens."

Their voice sounded like thousands of thunderbolts striking at once...

Yet carried an indescribable sense of peace.

"On your world..."

"You call us Gods."

"But we are not miracles, Ishaan."

"We are science."

"Science so ancient...

...that your civilization mistakes it for magic."

"Were you the ones who created us?"

The Cristosapien remained silent for a moment.

Then answered.

"We transferred fragments of our power to your planet... nine different times."

"Whenever your world stood on the edge of extinction..."

"We sent our knowledge."

"Our technology."

"Our Avatars."

"So your species could survive."

"Nine times..."

"We prevented your destruction."

"But the tenth time..."

"The Tenth Avatar..."

"You may have to save yourselves."

Ishaan listened quietly.

Then asked the only question that truly mattered.

"Can I change time?"

"Can I save the people I've already lost?"

The Cristosapiens slowly stepped back.

For the first time...

There was sadness in their glowing eyes.

"Time is not a thread you can cut, Ishaan."

"It is a loop."

"What has happened..."

"...will happen."

"And what is happening..."

"...has already happened."

Everything disappeared.

In the next instant...

Ishaan was back inside the Waqt-Rath.

He finally understood.

He could never save Anjali.

He could never erase Kenji's grief.

Time wasn't meant to be rewritten.

It was meant to be lived.

He gripped the controls.

Turned the ship around.

And headed back.

Cut To: Nebula

The four of them—

Kenji,

Mikhail,

Bhuvan,

and Avika—

Were still stranded on the ocean world.

They had given it a name.

Nebula.

The Nebulian miners continued digging.

Hour after hour.

Day after day.

The work never stopped.

It never did.

Then...

One night...

A different light emerged from the deepest part of the ocean.

Deep violet.

Brilliant.

Radiant.

The Life Syrup.

The reward of thousands of years of searching.

Sealed inside a single glowing crystal.

The Nebulians looked at one another.

Their eyes filled with joy.

Relief.

Even tears.

But before their celebration could begin—

The sky turned black.

Thousands of Indovarian warships descended from above.

Fast.

Perfectly organized.

They had come for the Life Syrup.

War erupted instantly.

The Nebulians possessed incredible technology.

The Indovarians possessed overwhelming numbers.

Energy weapons clashed across the ocean.

Shields exploded.

Entire waves rose into the sky from the force of the battle.

The four humans hid behind the wreckage of a destroyed Nebulian vessel.

Explosions echoed around them.

Light.

Darkness.

Light again.

"We need to get out of here," Bhuvan whispered.

"How?" Avika asked.

"Our ship is gone."

An Indovarian soldier began approaching them.

Steadily.

Mercilessly.

Bhuvan instinctively moved in front of Avika.

Kenji grabbed Mikhail's hand.

The soldier came closer.

Closer.

Then—

CRASH!

A familiar spacecraft burst into the battlefield.

Small.

Sleek.

Covered in reflective armor.

It slammed directly into the soldier, throwing him across the battlefield.

The hatch opened.

Ishaan.

"Get inside."

"Now."

The four of them ran.

Avika jumped aboard last.

The hatch sealed shut.

The Waqt-Rath accelerated.

Crossing time once again.

Returning...

To their own era.

Back on Earth.

Everyone had survived.

Everyone was alive.

But the moment they stepped out of the spacecraft...

Bhuvan looked straight at Ishaan.

He didn't hesitate.

"You ejected us."

Ishaan remained silent.

"Without telling us."

"Without asking."

His voice carried anger.

But beneath it...

Something deeper.

"We could've ended up anywhere."

"In any point in time."

"I knew you'd survive," Ishaan answered quietly.

"You knew?" Avika said.

For the first time...

The warmth in her voice was gone.

"You assumed."

"You made that decision for all of us."

"Without asking."

Mikhail said nothing.

Her eyes said enough.

Kenji placed a hand on Ishaan's shoulder...

But remained silent.

Silence filled the room.

Days passed.

Slowly...

Conversations happened.

Ishaan explained everything.

His meeting with the Cristosapiens.

The truth about the Time Loop.

Why Anjali could never be saved.

Why he had acted alone.

"If I had asked..."

"No one would've agreed."

"And there wasn't enough time."

"It was the wrong decision..."

"...but I had a reason."

Eventually...

Kenji understood.

Then Bhuvan.

Then Mikhail.

But Avika...

Remained quiet.

Weeks later...

It was Bhuvan and Mikhail's wedding.

A day filled with flowers.

Laughter.

Music.

Even Kenji smiled for the first time in months.

Ishaan noticed Avika standing alone in one corner.

She wore the expression of someone carrying unspoken feelings...

While pretending everything was normal.

He walked over to her.

Without saying a word...

He placed a small box in her hands.

She opened it.

Inside...

Was a bracelet.

Unlike any bracelet ever made.

Forged at the junction where space and time bent together.

It carried the glow of Nebula.

The light of the Cristosapiens.

Fragments of time itself.

All woven into a single piece.

"It will always keep you close to me," Ishaan said softly.

Avika looked at the bracelet.

Then...

At Ishaan.

There was still something hidden inside her eyes.

But the silence had begun to melt.

She slowly held out her hand.

Ishaan fastened the bracelet around her wrist.

Avika smiled.

Small.

Incomplete.

But real.

Post Credit: Dark Shadow

Many years ago.

A narrow, deserted alley.

The evening sky was covered in a dull haze.

A little boy sat on the ground with his head resting on his knees. His school bag lay a few feet away in the dirt. His eyes were dry. He had cried so much that there were no tears left.

Suddenly...

The air became heavy.

A glowing blue crack opened in the sky, as if an old page of reality had been torn apart.

A figure fell out of it.

Manvik.

Half of his damaged suit still covered his body. Broken wires glowed beneath his skin like burning veins. His face was filled with pain, exhaustion...

...and strangely, peace.

He staggered toward the young Ishaan.

The little boy looked up in fear.

A terrifying half-human face was standing right in front of him.

He couldn't even scream.

Manvik slowly raised his trembling hand.

Very gently...

He placed it on young Ishaan's head.

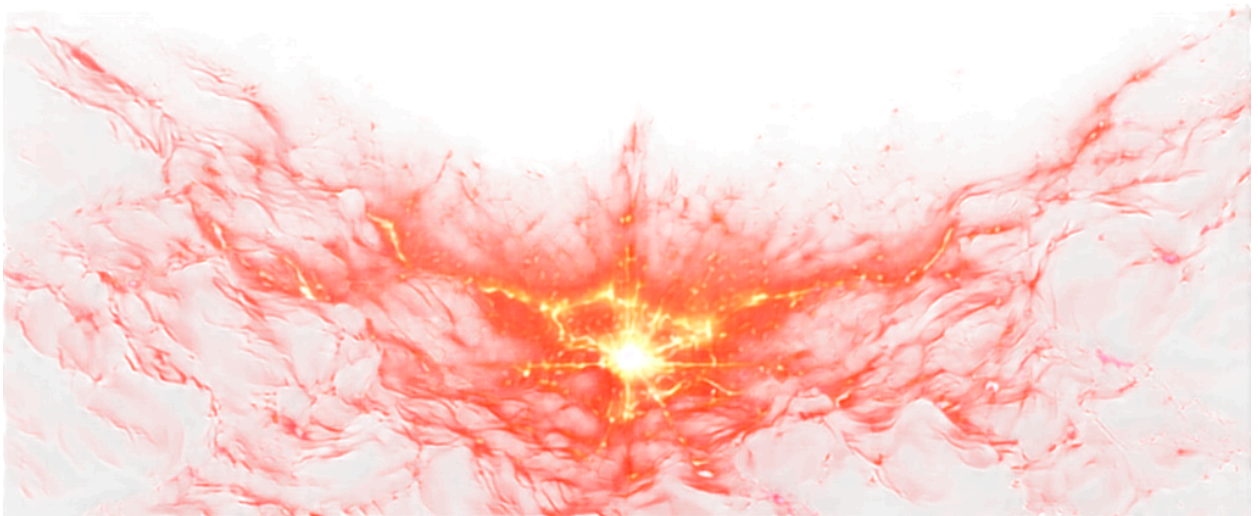
Silence.

Everything in the alley stopped.

Just for a moment.

A moment that felt like eternity.

FRACTURE ARC



Chapter 1: Criminal

When Ishaan returned to India after leaving the gleaming corridors of NASA, the world believed it was the return of a victorious hero.

But for Ishaan, it was just another race.

After **INDOVAR**, the world had called him a **Hero**. After creating the **Waqt-Rath**, they called him a **Legend**. But to Ishaan, those titles felt like an invisible weight—always resting on his shoulders, even if no one could see it.

He laid the foundation of his company—**IKS. Ishaan Kinetic Systems**.

The headquarters was enormous, built from glass and steel in the heart of the city. It sparkled from the outside.

Inside, the silence was even greater.

Most evenings, Ishaan stood by the giant laboratory window, staring at the city below.

The people who called him a god never knew that this "God" barely slept.

That sometimes, he simply stood there... looking outside for no reason at all.

Professor Kenji had returned to America to work on NASA's new projects, but their daily video calls remained one of the few things keeping Ishaan grounded.

"Ishaan, you've locked yourself inside a fortress," Kenji would often say.

Ishaan would only smile.

Meanwhile, Avika had cleared her CA exams.

Successful. Independent.

But her heart was still waiting for the same "Invisible" Ishaan—the boy who once went unnoticed, but now was seen by the entire world... except himself.

Whenever her family showed her photographs of potential grooms, she barely looked at them.

She was waiting.

For how long...

Even she didn't know.

Then one afternoon...

Everything changed.

The sky suddenly began changing its color.

The blue slowly faded into a deep, dirty crimson.

Then...

The cracks appeared.

Across the world, strange **Red Portals** began tearing open in the sky.

Some were no bigger than a ring.

Others were so enormous that their thunder made the Earth tremble.

NASA reported that one of Jupiter's moons had been swallowed by one of those portals...

...as if someone had erased it from the universe.

Panic spread across the globe.

Cities descended into chaos.

No one knew what the portals were.

Where they had come from.

Or when they would disappear.

But some people thought they knew.

Or perhaps...

...they simply needed someone to blame.

It was the inauguration day of **IKS**.

Thousands of people stood outside the building.

Cameras.

Media.

Celebration.

The beginning of a new era.

Ishaan stood on the stage with a microphone in his hand.

He looked across the crowd one last time.

The cameras.

The lights.

The faces.

He had barely begun speaking when—

A convoy of black vehicles screeched to a halt.

Senior NASA officials stepped out, accompanied by armed officers.

They walked straight onto the stage.

One officer stood beside Ishaan, took the microphone, and announced before the entire world—

"Ishaan Kumar Singh... you are accused of causing these Red Portals. This global catastrophe is believed to be the consequence of your time-travel experiments."

Silence swallowed the crowd.

Then...

Chaos erupted.

For the first time...

Ishaan had no answer.

He knew he had interfered with the laws of physics.

But he had never imagined the consequences could become this catastrophic.

The handcuffs came out.

They weren't placed only around his wrists.

They were placed around the trust the world once had in him.

In front of every camera.

In front of the entire world.

AIR 1.

Cyber-God.

Today...

A Criminal.

Chapter 2: Dimensional Nexus

Inside the cold, damp walls of the prison, Ishaan sat alone.

Outside, the world wanted his blood.

People had begun calling him "The Killer of the Universe."

News channels were filled with experts explaining why the Red Portals had appeared.

And every discussion ended with the same name.

Ishaan Kumar Singh.

Then...

Avika arrived.

She didn't say a word.

She simply held Ishaan's hand.

It was ice cold.

In that brief silence, more was spoken than words ever could.

"Where's Bhuvan bhai?" Ishaan asked softly.

"He took Mikhail to the hospital," Avika replied, her eyes moist. *"She suddenly felt dizzy... and started vomiting. He's really worried, Ishaan."*

Jitendar used every connection and recommendation he had.

Eventually...

Ishaan was granted bail.

The moment he reached the lab, Bhuvan called.

His voice was trembling—

Not with fear...

But with happiness.

"Ishaan... Mikhail is pregnant! I'm... I'm going to be a father!"

For a brief moment, a smile appeared on Ishaan's face.

He congratulated him warmly.

But as soon as the call ended...

He looked outside at the crimson sky.

A new life was about to begin.

While the entire universe stood on the edge of destruction.

The very next day...

Professor Kenji arrived in India.

The laboratory remained dark.

Only the crimson glow of countless monitors illuminated their faces.

Ishaan projected a complex mathematical model onto the main screen.

"Sir... until now our Multiverse remained stable like a four-dimensional sphere," he explained calmly.

"But according to SAHAY's latest readings... it has transformed into a four-dimensional cube..."

"A Dimensional Nexus."

"This isn't natural."

"Something is pulling us toward the center of that Nexus... like a spider drawing prey into its web."

Kenji carefully studied the model.

"Then what do we do?"

"We go to the center."

"Whatever is waiting there..."

"We stop it."

Seeing Mikhail's condition...

And Kenji's advancing age...

Ishaan made a firm decision.

"Both of you will stay here."

"We'll go."

Kenji protested immediately.

But the determination in Ishaan's eyes ended the argument before it could begin.

The laboratory became alive once again.

Days blended into nights.

The Waqt-Rath had suffered severe damage after the PARADOX mission.

Now Ishaan rebuilt it from the ground up.

A new engine.

A stronger shield system.

An advanced navigation core capable of reading and surviving the unstable portals surrounding the Dimensional Nexus.

SAHAY worked at full capacity—

Processing unimaginable amounts of data...

Calculating thousands of possible routes every second.

Every morning...

Avika arrived at the lab.

She didn't know how to code.

She couldn't help with physics.

But she was there.

She brought coffee.

Sometimes she simply sat beside him.

And for Ishaan...

Sometimes...

Just having someone beside him was enough.

One night...

After everyone else had gone home...

Avika stayed behind.

"Ishaan..." she spoke softly.

"Is this really necessary?"

"Isn't there any other way?"

Ishaan finally looked up from his laptop.

There was fear in her eyes.

Not the fear of death...

The fear of losing someone.

"If there were another way..." Ishaan replied quietly,

"I'd choose it."

"But this..."

"This is something only I can do."

Avika didn't argue.

She simply nodded.

That night...

The two of them remained in the laboratory.

Bathed in the pale glow of computer screens.

Neither of them spoke another word.

Yet both understood...

That what remained unspoken carried far more weight than anything they could have said aloud.

A few days later...

The Waqt-Rath was finally complete.

No...

It wasn't the same old ship anymore.

It had evolved.

Stronger.

Faster.

Built to survive dimensional portals...

To cross space-time itself...

And reach the heart of the Dimensional Nexus.

Ishaan stood silently, looking at the ship as it gleamed beneath the laboratory lights.

Avika walked over and stood beside him.

Their eyes met.

It was the kind of look shared by two people who both knew what lay ahead...

But neither wanted to say it.

Ishaan opened the hatch.

"SAHAY... run a full systems check."

"All systems are operational, Ishaan," SAHAY replied.

"The center of the Dimensional Nexus lies beyond four portals."

Ishaan stepped inside.

Avika followed.

The moment the ship entered the first portal—

A violent shockwave struck the Waqt-Rath...

Hurling them beyond the fabric of space and time.

Chapter 3: An Unknown Friend

When Ishaan opened his eyes, all he could see was dust and smoke.

The ship had crashed.

Not on Earth.

Not anywhere familiar.

The sky wasn't blue.

The ground didn't feel natural.

A heavy darkness stretched endlessly in every direction, as if the sun had never visited this universe.

There was air...

But it didn't feel breathable.

It was heavier.

Unnatural.

"Avika!" Ishaan shouted.

"I'm here!" a trembling voice answered from a short distance away.

She was sitting beside a massive rock, holding her head.

She wasn't seriously injured...

But she was clearly shaken.

The two rushed toward each other.

"SAHAY... where are we?" Ishaan asked.

"A different universe," SAHAY replied.

"One of the portals on the path to the Dimensional Nexus opened incorrectly. This universe is unstable, Ishaan."

"Darkness is the dominant force here."

"It's present in everything... everywhere."

Ishaan looked around.

Black mist covered the landscape.

There were no birds.

No wind.

Only an overwhelming silence...

The kind that seeped deep into the soul.

"What about the ship?" Avika asked.

Ishaan turned around.

Half of the Waqt-Rath was buried beneath the ground.

Smoke poured from its destroyed engine.

"It's not flying again," he said quietly.

"We'll have to find another way."

As they continued walking...

They realized this world wasn't merely dark.

It was dangerous.

Shapes emerged from the mist.

Some moved on four legs.

Others were so enormous that only fragments of their bodies could be seen.

Without warning...

A gigantic creature lunged straight toward Avika.

Fast.

Silent.

Ishaan spun the Astra Ring.

"Astra... Sword Mode!"

A flash of blue lightning illuminated the darkness.

The creature collapsed.

"Stay close," Ishaan said.

"Don't wander off."

Together...

They kept walking through the endless darkness.

Searching for even the smallest sign of light.

Eventually...

They saw one.

A faint glow in the distance.

It came from the ruins of an abandoned laboratory.

The building was ancient.

Half its walls had collapsed.

Inside, a few damaged monitors flickered weakly.

Ishaan and Avika stepped inside.

In one corner...

A man sat alone.

His hair was messy.

His clothes were worn out.

An empty glass rested in his hand.

The exhaustion in his eyes wasn't physical.

It was the exhaustion of someone who had been alone...

For far too long.

Hearing footsteps...

He slowly looked up.

He stared at Ishaan.

From head to toe.

Then at Avika.

Then back at Ishaan again.

Confusion spread across his face.

As if he desperately wanted to believe what he was seeing...

But couldn't trust his own eyes.

Ishaan slowly raised a hand.

"We're not here to hurt you."

The man didn't answer.

He quietly stood up...

Walked to another corner of the room...

And continued watching Ishaan from a distance.

Like a wild animal seeing another human being for the first time.

Not afraid.

Not trusting.

Simply...

Observing.

Finally, he spoke.

"You're Ishaan."

His voice was barely above a whisper.

Almost as if he were talking to himself.

"Yes."

"And you are?"

"Om."

For the first hour...

Om refused to let them come any closer.

He remained seated at a distance.

Every few moments, he looked at Ishaan...

Then quickly looked away.

Some old memory was holding him back.

Ishaan didn't force a conversation.

He simply sat there.

Avika did the same.

SAHAY spoke quietly through the earpiece.

"He's been alone for a very long time, Ishaan."

"His behavioral patterns suggest prolonged isolation."

Nearly an hour later...

Om finally asked,

"Where did you come from?"

"Another universe," Ishaan answered honestly.

Om remained silent for a moment.

Then he quietly said,

"In my universe... Ishaan died."

Silence filled the room.

"I'm not that Ishaan," Ishaan replied softly.

This time...

Om didn't look away.

Slowly...

Very slowly...

He walked closer.

He carefully examined Ishaan.

His face.

His eyes.

The Astra Ring.

"That ring..." Om murmured.

"The Ishaan from my universe had one too."

"I know."

Om sat down directly across from him.

For the first time.

"Why are you here?"

Ishaan explained everything.

The Dimensional Nexus.

The Red Portals.

The unknown force manipulating reality itself.

Om listened carefully.

Without interrupting once.

When Ishaan finished...

Om lowered his eyes.

"The Ishaan from my universe was trying to stop something similar."

"Then the SAJ-26 virus came."

"Everyone died."

"I'm the only one left."

His voice carried no emotion.

No anger.

No grief.

Only emptiness.

He had repeated that story so many times...

That even pain had disappeared.

Avika quietly wiped away the tears forming in her eyes.

She said nothing.

That night...

No one slept.

Om told them everything about his universe.

The sun hadn't risen in years.

Almost no one remained alive.

Only a handful of survivors hiding deep beneath the surface.

Ishaan listened silently.

Never interrupting.

When Om finally finished...

Ishaan spoke.

"We have to reach the center of the Nexus."

"Our ship is destroyed."

"We need another way."

Om stood up.

He walked toward the far corner of the laboratory.

Several dusty mechanical components lay buried beneath debris.

"These belonged to the Ishaan of my universe," he said quietly.

"I kept them safe."

"I never understood the technology..."

"But I couldn't throw them away."

Ishaan carefully picked up the components.

Studied them.

Analyzed them.

"SAHAY... what can we build from these?"

"A portable portal device," SAHAY replied.

"It can be worn on the wrist."

"Press a single button..."

"And it will open a direct path to the coordinates of the Dimensional Nexus."

"But there's a limitation."

"Only two people can use it."

"You... and Avika."

"Om will have to stay here."

Ishaan looked toward Om.

Om understood immediately.

He simply nodded.

"I'm fine here."

"I'm used to it."

That single sentence...

Carried more loneliness than an entire lifetime.

Together...

They began building the device.

Avika handed over the components.

SAHAY handled the calculations.

Ishaan assembled the technology.

Om contributed everything he remembered about the alien systems left behind in his universe.

By sunrise...

Two sleek wrist-mounted devices were complete.

Waqt-Bandh.

Ishaan fastened one around his wrist.

Avika wore the other.

Om stood silently in the distance.

His face remained expressionless.

But something had returned to his eyes...

Perhaps for the first time in years.

Hope.

Ishaan looked at him.

"We'll come back."

Om gave a faint smile.

"The Ishaan from my universe..."

"He said the same thing."

Silence followed.

Then...Ishaan pressed the button.

Chapter 4: An Old Enemy

The **Wagt-Bandh** worked.

One moment there was darkness...

The next—

An endless sea of white light.

Ishaan and Avika had arrived at the very heart of the **Dimensional Nexus**.

There was no ground beneath their feet.

Only an infinite white expanse stretching in every direction.

Around them floated countless fragments of the Multiverse, as though reality itself had shattered like glass.

Each fragment contained an entire universe.

"SAHAY... do you detect anything?" Ishaan asked.

"Yes."

"There is a presence at the center of the Nexus."

"Ancient..."

"And unimaginably powerful."

Avika tightened her grip around Ishaan's hand.

"Let's keep moving."

Then...

They saw him.

A lone figure stood perfectly still in the distance.

Like a statue.

As Ishaan and Avika approached...

The figure slowly turned.

Ishaan's breathing stopped.

Manvik.

But not the Manvik he had known.

This Manvik carried a coldness in his eyes that only billions of years of loneliness could create.

His face was familiar...

Everything else was different.

The nanotech wiring from the damaged prototype suit still covered his body—

Only now...

It had fused into his skin.

Become a part of him.

In his hand rested a strange trident.

Not forged from metal...

But from crystallized energy itself.

"Do you really think you're special, Ishaan?"

Manvik's voice echoed throughout the entire Nexus.

From every direction...

At the same time.

Ishaan activated the Astra Ring.

"Manvik... stop this."

"The portals..."

"The destruction..."

Manvik laughed.

There was no joy in it.

Only emptiness.

"Stop?"

"Instead of giving up..."

"I searched every universe..."

"Every timeline..."

"Every weak version of Ishaan I could find."

"I killed them."

"I took their intelligence."

"Today..."

"The minds of millions of Ishaan Kumar Singhs live inside me."

He slowly raised the trident.

The first strike came.

A massive wave of energy exploded from the weapon.

So powerful that even the white light of the Nexus turned black for a brief instant.

Ishaan instantly created an energy shield with the Astra Ring.

The impact was overwhelming.

He was thrown backward.

There wasn't even any ground to stand on.

He barely managed to stop himself from falling into the endless void.

"Astra... Mace Mode!"

A massive purple energy mace formed in his hand.

Ishaan swung with all his strength.

Manvik casually raised one hand.

The mace froze in mid-air.

As though time itself had stopped.

"Is that all?" Manvik asked.

He moved a single finger.

The mace reversed direction...

And slammed straight back into Ishaan.

The impact hurled him across the Nexus.

Pain shot through every bone in his body.

"Astra... Sword Mode!"

The blade appeared instantly.

Ignoring the pain, Ishaan charged forward again.

One strike.

Then another.

Then another.

Every attack carried every ounce of strength he had left.

For the first time...

Manvik stepped backward.

Once.

Twice.

Then—

He planted the trident into the invisible floor of the Nexus.

A violent vibration erupted through reality itself.

Ishaan almost lost his grip on the sword.

Manvik lifted the weapon again.

Then began walking toward him.

Slowly.

Confidently.

Without the slightest urgency.

As if the outcome had already been decided.

"You're exhausted, Ishaan."

"I've existed for billions of years."

"You've barely lived a few decades."

Ishaan clenched his teeth.

"Astra... Bow Mode!"

An energy bow materialized in his hands.

Arrow after arrow shot across the Nexus.

Blinding streaks of blue light surrounded Manvik.

For a single moment...

He stopped.

Only...

For a single moment.

Then Manvik raised his hand.

An invisible force wrapped around Ishaan's body.

He was lifted into the air.

Helpless.

A second later—

He was slammed violently back down.

The impact echoed throughout the Nexus.

Ishaan lay motionless.

Gasping for breath.

He tried to stand.

His legs failed.

Once.

Twice.

On the third attempt...

He forced himself back up.

Despite the pain.

Despite the blood.

"Astra... Parshu Mode!"

A massive energy axe appeared.

With a roar, Ishaan swung it directly at Manvik's trident.

The two weapons collided.

A deafening explosion shook the Dimensional Nexus.

Purple energy erupted in every direction.

Even the endless white light surrounding them turned violet.

Then—

CRACK.

A sharp metallic sound echoed.

The Astra Ring...

Shattered.

Fragments scattered through the air.

Only an empty ring remained around Ishaan's wrist.

No energy.

No weapons.

Nothing.

Ishaan stared silently at his hand.

Manvik looked at the broken ring.

Then smiled.

"Now what?" he asked softly.

Ishaan stood there—

Wounded.

Exhausted.

Alone.

The broken remains of the Astra Ring still clutched in his hand.

Avika was trapped in the distance, held in place by Manvik's energy field.

"SAHAY..." Ishaan whispered.

SAHAY...

Didn't answer.

For the first time...

Chapter 5: Fracture

Manvik slowly raised his Trident.

A massive field of violet energy spread across the Dimensional Nexus, dense and crushing, closing in from every direction until it surrounded both Ishaan and Avika.

"Neither of you are of any use to me anymore," Manvik said, his voice echoing across the endless white void. "But I won't kill you."

He looked into Ishaan's eyes.

"I'll send you somewhere you'll never escape."

Ishaan thrust both hands forward, desperately trying to resist the energy.

But the Astra Ring was gone.

Broken.

No weapons.

No power.

The field tightened.

"SAHAY! Do something!" Ishaan shouted.

"Ishaan... I can't. This energy belongs to the entire Nexus—"

A violent shockwave tore through reality.

Their connection shattered.

The world split apart.

Two separate portals swallowed them whole.

War Universe

When Ishaan opened his eyes, explosions were already shaking the air.

The sky was black.

The ground was buried beneath gunpowder, twisted steel, and mountains of broken machines. This world had been at war for centuries.

His first instinct was to find Avika.

She was there.

Alive.

For now.

"Activate the Waqt-Bandh," Ishaan said immediately. "We leave. Now."

Avika reached for the device strapped to her wrist.

Her trembling fingers slipped.

Sweat.

Fear.

The device slid free and flew into a pile of shattered rubble several meters away.

Both of them watched it disappear.

Then...

The ruined building beside them groaned.

It leaned.

Slowly.

Then faster.

"Ishaan! My device—!"

There was a fear in Avika's voice that Ishaan had never heard before.

Not the fear of death.

The fear of knowing that your own mistake might destroy someone else's life.

Ishaan lunged toward her.

But the first wall of collapsing debris crashed between them.

"AVIKAAA!"

"ISHAAAAN!"

Then—

Hundreds of tons of concrete.

Twisted iron beams.

A storm of dust.

Everything vanished beneath it.

The dust refused to settle.

Ishaan stood frozen.

He didn't move.

He didn't breathe.

"...Avika."

He spoke softly.

As if saying her name gently might change reality.

No answer.

"Avika."

Louder this time.

Still...

Nothing.

He ran.

Throwing rocks aside with his bare hands.

One.

Another.

Another.

The stones were impossibly heavy.

His fingernails cracked.

He kept digging.

His hands turned red.

He kept digging.

He couldn't stop.

Because stopping meant accepting it.

And he couldn't.

He simply couldn't.

When the dust finally began to clear...

A hand emerged from beneath the rubble.

Cold.

Motionless.

Ishaan stared at it.

For a long time.

His mind had stopped processing.

Time itself seemed frozen.

Around that wrist was the bracelet he had made for her...

Forged at the junction where space and time bent into one another.

A bracelet carrying the light of Nebula.

The brilliance of the Cristosapiens.

Once radiant.

Now...

Covered in blood.

Slowly...

Ishaan knelt beside it.

He took her cold hand into both of his.

He held it there.

As though holding it tighter would bring warmth back.

As though refusing to let go would keep her from leaving.

Then...

He pressed her hand against his forehead.

And simply...

Sat there.

Amid the rubble.

Missiles screamed across the sky.

Buildings burned.

The world continued to wage its endless war.

But Ishaan heard none of it.

Saw none of it.

Something inside him had broken.

Silently.

There was no scream.

No tears.

No rage.

Only an emptiness so vast...

So impossibly deep...

That it had no bottom.

As though an entire universe had been hollowed out from within him—

Leaving behind nothing but silence.

He remained there...

For what felt like forever.

The Waqt-Bandh was still fastened to his own wrist.

He looked at it.

Once.

Then again.

Finally...

He pressed the button.

A blue portal burst open inside the laboratory.

Bhuvan.

Mikhail.

Kenji.

All three rushed toward it, their faces filled with hope, relief...

And questions.

Then they saw him.

And stopped.

Ishaan stood motionless.

His clothes were torn.

His body was covered in dust and dried blood.

But it was his eyes that froze them.

Those eyes...

The eyes that were always searching...

Always calculating...

Always looking toward tomorrow...

Were empty.

Like an abandoned house whose door still stood open...

Long after everyone inside had left.

There was only one thing in his hand.

Avika's bracelet.

The same bracelet.

Cold.

Stained crimson with blood.

"Ishaan..."

Bhuvan's voice trembled.

He couldn't even finish the question.

Just a name.

Yet that single name carried every question imaginable.

"Where's Avika?"

Ishaan never answered.

He looked at Bhuvan for a brief moment.

Then looked away.

Silently...

He walked past all of them.

As though he wasn't truly there anymore.

As though a part of him had been left behind in another universe.

His footsteps no longer carried certainty.

No purpose.

No destination.

Only weight.

He walked because he no longer had the strength to stop.

He entered his room.

The door closed.

Locked from the inside.

Silence consumed the laboratory.

The monitors still glowed.

Data still streamed across the screens.

Signals kept arriving.

From the outside...

Everything appeared normal.

Inside...

Nothing was.

After a long while...

A sound came from behind the door.

Soft sobs.

Not ordinary crying.

This was the kind of grief that came when a person had nowhere left to place their pain.

When sorrow became too vast to escape...

Too immense to contain...

So it simply kept breaking them.

Again.

And again.

Without end.

Mikhail quietly reached for Bhuvan's hand.

His eyes filled with tears.

The same eyes that had remained dry through ISRO's greatest crises...

Through the darkness of space itself...

Could no longer hold them back.

Kenji stood beside the laboratory window.

Outside...

The night was calm.

Dark.

Silent.

Just like the pain no one else could see—

Yet was undeniably there.

Three people.

Standing in three different places.

Feeling the same unbearable truth.

Something had ended.

Something that would never return.

The portals might one day close.

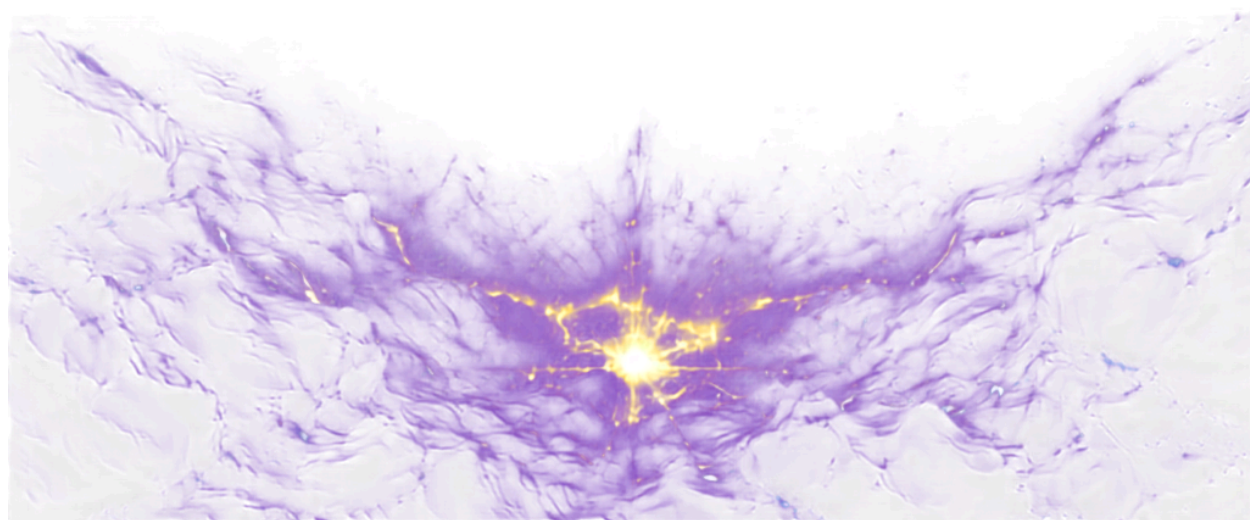
Manvik might one day fall.

The universe itself might one day be saved.

But the fracture inside Ishaan...

Would never heal.

ASCENT ARC



Chapter 1: The Closed Door

The world had fallen into mourning.

And fear.

The sky had lost its familiar shade of blue. In its place hung a deep, terrifying crimson, stretching endlessly across the heavens. The walls separating the multiverse had grown dangerously thin. Entire universes drifted so close together that people could see distant mountains... alien cities... and unfamiliar worlds suspended in the sky.

No one dared step outside.

The cities stood empty.

The streets were silent.

Everyone believed the end was near.

The silence inside the IKS Laboratory was different.

Deeper.

Heavier.

There was a single door.

Locked.

From the inside.

Every day, Bhuvan walked to that door carrying a tray of food.

Sometimes he left it there.

Sometimes he simply stood outside...

Listening to the silence on the other side.

No answer ever came.

Amid the growing panic, a new face arrived at the laboratory.

Om.

He belonged to this universe, yet he had never met Ishaan before.

Like everyone else, he had heard the stories.

Ishaan Kumar Singh.

SAHAY.

INDOVAR.

Legends that had spread across the world.

When Bhuvan looked into Om's eyes, he saw something painfully familiar.

The same relentless determination...

The same burning curiosity...

The same fire that had once lived in Ishaan.

Without asking a single question, Bhuvan welcomed him into the team.

Days turned into nights.

Om and Bhuvan buried themselves in SAHAY's data.

Dimensional Nexus patterns.

Manvik's energy signatures.

Portal frequencies.

Every equation only created more questions.

One night, exhaustion finally caught up with them.

Om hesitated before speaking.

"Sir..."

His voice was cautious.

"Where is Ishaan, sir? I've been here for days... but I've never seen him."

Bhuvan's hands froze above the keyboard.

Slowly...

He looked toward the closed door.

Silence filled the room.

It wasn't that he didn't know the answer.

He simply didn't know how to say it.

"Ever since he returned from the Dimensional Nexus..." Bhuvan said quietly, "...he hasn't stepped out of that room."

His voice felt heavier with every word.

"We leave food outside the door. Sometimes he eats a bite or two."

He paused.

"He hasn't told us what happened in there."

Another pause.

"And Avika..."

The sentence never reached its end.

It didn't need to.

Om understood.

He never asked another question.

Both of them stared at the closed door.

Behind it...

There was only silence.

Yet somehow...

That silence was slowly consuming the entire laboratory.

It was long past midnight.

Inside the dark room...

Ishaan sat alone.

His beard had grown wild.

His face had turned pale.

Dark circles hollowed the skin beneath his eyes.

His trembling hands held only one thing.

Avika's bracelet.

He was gripping it so tightly that his nails dug into his own palm.

The room was completely dark.

No lights.

No sound.

Only memories.

Again.

And again.

And again.

Avika.

Her gentle smile.

Her warm voice.

Her cold, lifeless hand.

The bracelet...

Once filled with the light of Nebula...

Now stained forever with blood.

Ishaan closed his eyes.

From exhaustion.

From grief.

From pain.

Then...

The darkness disappeared.

He was no longer inside his room.

An endless white light stretched infinitely in every direction.

The same place.

The same presence.

The Cristosapiens.

This time...

Ishaan didn't hesitate.

He walked straight toward them.

Halfway there...

His knees gave out.

He collapsed.

"You told me..."

His voice cracked beneath the weight of grief.

"You said that whenever humanity faces its greatest crisis... you grant your power."

His breathing became uneven.

"I need that power."

"I have to fix this."

"I have to bring her back..."

"Please..."

The last word shattered into silence.

The Cristosapiens answered.

Their voices resonated through the endless light like the echo of ancient bells.

"No, Ishaan."

One word.

Yet it carried the weight of eternity.

His crying stopped.

Slowly, he looked up.

"No?"

His eyes were bloodshot.

His face was exhausted.

"You do not need our power."

The luminous beings stood motionless.

"What you're asking for..."

"...is something even we cannot give."

A long silence followed.

"Time is a loop."

"We have already told you this."

"What has happened..."

"...has happened."

Ishaan lowered his head.

"So Avika..."

"She is gone."

The words were gentle.

But absolute.

"And this pain..."

"It belongs to you."

"Feel it."

"Do not run from it."

Ishaan closed his eyes.

For a long moment.

Then whispered,

"What am I supposed to do?"

His voice was barely audible.

"So small it seemed the light itself might carry it away."

"How..."

"...do I move forward?"

The Cristosapiens remained silent for a moment.

Then one of them spoke.

"Return."

"Finish what you started."

"When the right moment arrives..."

"Power will find you on its own."

"But not yet."

"Now..."

"You must stand."

A sudden jolt.

The white light vanished.

Ishaan was back inside his room.

Darkness surrounded him once again.

Avika's bracelet still rested in his hand.

Silence filled the room.

Outside...

Om and Bhuvan continued working.

Screens flickered.

Data streamed endlessly.

Inside...

Behind the closed door...

Ishaan remained seated.

His eyes closed.

His fingers wrapped around the bracelet.

He wasn't back.

Not yet.

But somewhere deep within the darkness...

Something existed now that hadn't before.

A spark.

So small...

It was almost invisible.

Yet...

It was there.

Chapter 2: The Angel Returns

The next morning...

Bhuvan and Om were buried beneath layers of SAHAY's data when every monitor in the laboratory suddenly began to beep.

SAHAY was updating itself.

Lines of code rewrote automatically across the screens.

Fast.

Precise.

Perfectly organized.

Bhuvan frowned.

"Who's running this update?"

"I am."

The voice behind them was calm.

Deep.

Cold.

Both of them turned.

Standing at the laboratory entrance...

Was Ishaan.

His beard was gone.

He wore fresh clothes.

The fear that had haunted his eyes the night before had disappeared.

The pain was still there...

But buried beneath something far stronger.

A quiet fire.

Calm.

Unshakable.

The look of a man who had already made his decision.

Completely.

Om immediately stood up.

His eyes widened.

The man he had admired for years was standing right in front of him.

He hurried forward.

"Sir... I'm Om—"

"I know."

Ishaan stopped him with nothing more than a small gesture of his hand.

There was authority in his voice.

The kind that demanded silence without ever raising itself.

Yet it wasn't arrogance.

It was simply the composure of someone who had lost too much...

And had nothing left to look at except the road ahead.

Bhuvan watched him carefully.

For a long moment.

Then finally gathered the courage to ask.

"Ishaan..."

"...where's Avika?"

Everything stopped.

For just a second.

Ishaan's jaw tightened.

His eyes drifted somewhere far away.

To a place no one else could reach.

A place where a cold hand rested beneath broken concrete.

Where a bloodstained bracelet lay.

Where a final cry still echoed forever.

Then...

He returned.

"Focus on the mission."

His voice was steady.

Final.

Bhuvan didn't ask again.

Neither did Om.

The rest of the day disappeared into work.

Ishaan examined every fragment of information.

Manvik's energy signature.

The Dimensional Nexus.

Portal frequencies.

Every variable.

Every possibility.

Not once did he pause.

Om worked beside him, feeding calculations into SAHAY, analyzing data, solving equations.

Every now and then...

He glanced toward Ishaan.

It was the same man he had admired.

And yet...

Not the same man at all.

As evening settled over the laboratory, Bhuvan quietly placed a cup of coffee beside him.

He didn't say a word.

He simply left.

Ishaan picked up the cup.

Took a sip.

It was the first thing he had eaten or drunk all day.

Late that night...

After everyone else had gone to sleep...

Bhuvan walked toward Ishaan's room.

A tray of food rested in his hands.

The same routine.

Every night.

Only this time...

The door was open.

He stepped inside.

Ishaan was sitting beside the window.

Watching the crimson sky in silence.

Avika's bracelet rested in his hand.

Bhuvan quietly placed the food on the table.

He turned to leave.

"Sit down, Bhai."

Bhuvan stopped.

Then sat beside him.

For several long moments...

Neither of them spoke.

Then...

Without warning...

The wall around Ishaan shattered.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

It simply...

Collapsed.

He leaned forward and wrapped his arms around Bhuvan.

Like a child.

And he cried.

Not ordinary tears.

These were the tears that came only after someone had spent far too long pretending to be strong.

When grief became too heavy to carry alone...

It found its own way out.

Between broken breaths...

He told Bhuvan everything.

Avika dropping the Waqt-Bandh.

The collapsing building.

His desperate attempt to reach her.

The avalanche of concrete.

Her cold hand beneath the rubble.

The bracelet...

Covered in blood.

Bhuvan never interrupted.

He offered no advice.

No comforting lies.

No empty promises that everything would be alright.

He simply held him.

Sometimes...

A hand on someone's shoulder says more than words ever could.

The following morning...

In a quiet corner of the laboratory...

They held a private prayer for Avika's soul.

There were no cameras.

No announcements.

No audience.

Only those who truly knew her.

Bhuvan.

Mikhail.

Kenji.

Om.

And Ishaan.

A sacred fire burned quietly.

The scent of incense filled the room.

Ancient chants echoed softly through the silence.

Ishaan stood before the flames.

Completely still.

The bloodstained bracelet rested in his hand.

He looked at it once.

Then at the fire.

There were no tears this time.

Only silence.

But this wasn't the empty silence that had consumed him before.

This one was different.

It belonged to someone who had accepted that pain would never leave...

Yet had chosen to keep walking anyway.

The fire slowly died.

Ishaan rose to his feet.

He looked at each of them.

Om.

Bhuvan.

Mikhail.

Kenji.

Then, quietly, he spoke.

"Let's get back to work."

Chapter 3: Bubble World

Silence filled the laboratory—but it was the silence of relentless work. The only sounds were the rhythmic tapping of keyboards, while cups of tea sat forgotten, growing cold because no one had the time to drink them.

Ishaan stood before the main screen. Om worked beside him, while Bhuvan compiled data at another terminal.

Then, without a word, Ishaan lifted his hands away from the keyboard.

Everyone looked up.

"There is only one way to stop Manvik," Ishaan said. There was no hesitation in his voice—as though the decision had been made long ago, and only the words remained to be spoken. "I have to defeat him. Face him directly. And I'll do it... alone."

"Alone?" Bhuvan stepped forward. "Ishaan—"

"Bhai."

Just one word.

Nothing more.

Bhuvan fell silent.

Om stared at the display showing Manvik's energy signature, which existed simultaneously across thousands of universes.

"Sir... if he's present in every universe, then he'll be watching every universe as well. The moment you make your move... he'll know. He'll already be prepared."

"I know," Ishaan replied.

"That's why I'm not going to approach him directly."

He walked to the whiteboard, uncapped a marker, and drew a small circle.

"Manvik controls every place that exists—no matter which universe it belongs to." He paused before adding, "But he cannot control something that doesn't exist."

Om frowned.

"Something... that doesn't exist?"

"An artificial pocket universe."

Ishaan tapped the small circle on the board.

"A Bubble World."

"I'll create it myself. None of Manvik's sensors will ever detect it, because it won't be a part of the real Multiverse. It'll be an isolated reality—a tiny world that exists only for as long as we need it."

Silence settled over the room.

Om looked at the diagram... then at Ishaan... then back at the whiteboard.

"This..." he murmured, almost convincing himself as he spoke, "...this could actually work."

"It will."

There was no confidence in Ishaan's voice.

Only certainty.

Creating the Bubble World was anything but easy.

Hours slipped away.

Day turned into night.

Night faded into another morning.

SAHAY operated at maximum capacity, processing impossible amounts of data. Om and Bhuvan worked in shifts—while one slept, the other continued feeding calculations into the system.

Ishaan never slept.

At last, the framework was complete.

An artificial pocket dimension.

Small enough that Manvik's sensors would never recognize it as part of reality.

Stable enough for them to work inside it.

"It's done," SAHAY announced.

"Bubble World is now active."

A gentle breeze drifted through the laboratory, as though something entirely new had just been born.

Now came the Astra Ring.

The previous ring had been destroyed inside the Dimensional Nexus by Manvik's Trident.

This one would be different.

More compact.

More refined.

More focused.

The original Astra Ring had only three combat modes.

The new one would possess five.

Throughout the night, SAHAY performed millions of calculations while Ishaan assembled every component by hand.

By dawn, the new Astra Ring rested around his wrist.

He began testing it.

First Mode—Bow.

Blue energy materialized into a flawless weapon.

Perfect.

Second Mode—Sword.

Sharp.

Elegant.

Precise.

Third Mode—Mace.

A massive weapon forged from deep violet energy.

Raw power.

Fourth Mode—Battle Axe.

Heavy.

Solid.

Devastating.

Then came the...

Fifth Mode.

Something entirely new.

Something the previous Astra Ring had never possessed.

Ishaan watched the symbol for a long moment.

Then he deactivated it.

Its time would come.

Only one task remained.

The Waqt-Bandh.

The original device could only navigate to the Dimensional Nexus.

Now it needed to access the Bubble World—and safely return from it.

Within an hour...

the upgraded Waqt-Bandh was complete.

Everything was ready.

Ishaan looked around the laboratory one last time.

Om.

Bhuvan.

Mikhail.

Kenji.

Om's eyes shimmered with something impossible to describe.

Fear.

Admiration.

Hope.

And something beyond words.

Bhuvan didn't say anything.

He simply stepped forward...

and pulled Ishaan into a tight embrace.

Ishaan returned it.

For a brief moment.

Then they let go.

Ishaan checked the Waqt-Bandh on his wrist.

The new Astra Ring gleamed beside it.

In his hand rested Avika's bracelet.

The same crimson-stained bracelet.

He looked at it once...

then carefully placed it inside the inner pocket of his jacket—

close to his heart.

"Manvik..." he whispered, not for anyone else to hear, but for himself alone.

"I'm coming."

He pressed the activation button on the Waqt-Bandh.

Chapter 4: Final Countdown

The Dimensional Nexus.

The same place.

The same endless white void.

The same shattered fragments of the Multiverse drifting in every direction, as though reality itself were nothing more than the broken pieces of a giant glass vessel.

A ripple of blue light appeared.

Ishaan stepped out of the Waqt-Bandh portal.

The new Astra Ring gleamed on his finger.

Ready.

For a long moment...

there was only silence.

Then—

he felt it.

A presence.

Ancient.

Overwhelming.

Heavy enough to bend the very air around it.

Manvik.

He stood exactly where he had before.

The prototype suit had fused completely with his body, its nanotech veins glowing beneath his skin.

The Trident rested in his hand.

His eyes still carried that chilling calm only billions of years of loneliness could create.

But this time...

there was something else in them.

Surprise.

"So..."

Manvik spoke at last.

"You came back."

His gaze narrowed.

"Alone."

"Yes."

Ishaan's reply was simple.

Nothing more.

Manvik studied him from head to toe.

Then a smile slowly spread across his face.

The kind of smile that never meant anything good.

"Leaving you alive..."

he said quietly,

"...was my mistake."

His voice carried no anger.

Only certainty.

"I won't make that mistake twice."

"Neither will I."

Manvik struck first.

The Trident erupted with a massive wave of violet energy, tearing straight toward Ishaan.

"Astra—Battle Axe!"

A colossal energy axe materialized in Ishaan's hands.

The two forces collided.

A blinding explosion erupted.

For a brief instant, the white light of the Nexus turned deep violet.

The shockwave hurled both of them backward.

Both recovered instantly.

Manvik attacked again.

This time—

two energy waves.

Different angles.

Different trajectories.

Ishaan raised both hands.

"Astra—Bow!"

A storm of glowing arrows shot forward, intercepting both attacks before they could reach him.

The Nexus trembled beneath the impact.

"Better than before."

Manvik tilted his head.

"But not enough."

He lowered the Trident and released an invisible force with his free hand.

Gravity itself twisted.

Ishaan's body was ripped into the air—

but before the force could crush him...

the Waqt-Bandh activated.

A micro-portal.

Barely open for a second.

He disappeared...

and emerged behind Manvik.

"Astra—Sword!"

A blade of blue lightning slashed across Manvik's shoulder.

For the first time—

Manvik moved.

Only slightly.

He glanced at the wound.

Then looked back at Ishaan.

A faint smile appeared.

"Good."

He slowly lifted the Trident.

"Now..."

"let's fight seriously."

What followed...

was a perfectly balanced battle.

Ishaan was faster.

The Waqt-Bandh created countless micro-portals, allowing him to attack from impossible angles.

Manvik was stronger.

Every strike carried the weight of billions of years.

Ishaan swung the Astra Mace with overwhelming force.

Manvik blocked it with the Trident.

The impact echoed across the Nexus.

Reality itself shuddered.

Manvik unleashed another massive energy wave.

Large enough to shake the entire dimension.

Ishaan attempted to escape through another portal—

but the blast grazed him.

He crashed to the ground.

Once.

Then stood again.

The Trident came down.

The Astra Bow intercepted it.

Attack.

Defend.

Dodge.

Counter.

Again.

Again.

Again.

Each of them understood the other completely.

Every move had a response.

Every trick had a counter.

Slowly...

something changed.

Manvik began to tire.

He was connected to countless universes—

but physically,

he was alone.

And no matter how powerful someone was...

fighting alone forever came with a cost.

Ishaan noticed it.

He accelerated.

No pauses.

No hesitation.

Bow.

Sword.

Mace.

Battle Axe.

Switching between weapons with relentless precision.

Manvik blocked every attack...

but he was being pushed back.

One step.

Then another.

Then another.

"You're getting tired."

Ishaan's voice remained calm.

Manvik said nothing.

But his breathing had become noticeably heavier.

Then—

he did something Ishaan never expected.

He planted the Trident into the floor—

even though the Nexus had no floor at all.

He closed his eyes.

One second.

Two.

Then—

the Nexus exploded with light.

Across countless universes...

his Prime Clones answered the call.

One.

Ten.

Hundreds.

Thousands.

Millions.

They appeared everywhere.

Above.

Below.

On every side.

Ishaan froze for the briefest moment.

"This..."

Manvik smiled.

"...isn't your Bubble World."

He spread his arms.

"This..."

"is my Nexus."

"And here..."

"I am millions."

Millions of Manviks.

Against...

one Ishaan.

The clones attacked.

From every direction at once.

Ishaan cycled through every mode of the Astra Ring.

One clone fell.

Another replaced it.

Two disappeared.

Four more arrived.

He opened micro-portals through the Waqt-Bandh, striking from impossible angles.

But there were simply...

too many.

Hours passed.

Or perhaps days.

Inside the Nexus,

time had no meaning.

One clone grabbed his left arm.

Another seized his right.

A third slammed into his back.

Ishaan fell.

The clones surrounded him.

Above.

Below.

Everywhere.

Then...

through the endless crowd...

the real Manvik walked forward.

Slowly.

Confidently.

Like a man who already knew how the story would end.

He bent down.

Wrapped one hand around Ishaan's throat.

And effortlessly lifted him into the air.

Ishaan struggled for breath.

His hands fought desperately to break free—

but the clones held both of his arms in place.

Madness burned within Manvik's eyes.

Pride.

Arrogance.

And something even darker...

the satisfaction of finally reaching the moment he had waited for across countless lifetimes.

"You can never defeat me, Ishaan."

His voice was almost gentle.

As he looked directly into Ishaan's eyes.

"I am the greatest mind in every universe."

"Every Ishaan that ever existed..."

"lives inside me."

"You..."

"...are only one."

"I..."

"...am millions."

Ishaan's vision blurred.

His breathing faded.

Slowly...

his eyes began to close.

Chapter 5: Singularity

Ishaan was running out of breath.

Manvik's grip was unbreakable. With one hand, he held Ishaan in the air while the clones restrained both of his arms. There was no escape. No weapon. The Waqt-Bandh was trapped beneath the clones' grip—impossible to activate.

His vision began to fade.

And within that darkness...

He saw Avika.

Her gentle smile.

Her voice saying,

"Go, Ishaan. The world is waiting for you."

That cold hand.

That bracelet.

Something had broken the day she died.

But something had survived.

And now...

That surviving piece awakened.

Something surged through Ishaan's veins—fast, glowing purple.

The bracelet resting inside his jacket, close to his heart, flashed for a brief moment.

Manvik felt it.

For the first time, his grip loosened.

His eyes widened in confusion.

Ishaan's body began to grow.

Slowly.

Then rapidly.

The clones tried to hold him back...

But he was already larger than them.

Then larger still.

Then larger.

Within seconds, Manvik's hand—the same hand gripping Ishaan's throat—began to disintegrate into glowing particles.

A scream echoed throughout the entire Nexus.

Ishaan kept growing.

Until he towered beyond the Dimensional Nexus itself.

A godlike being.

Light poured from his eyes with such brilliance that even the stars seemed dim beside it.

At that exact moment...

The sky tore open.

A colossal **Purple Sudarshan Chakra** descended from above.

It flew toward Manvik's clone army.

One by one...

Thousands...

Millions...

The clones were erased.

The Chakra never slowed.

It kept spinning.

Cutting.

Destroying.

Without stopping.

Then Cristosapiens' voice echoed across the Nexus.

"I told you... when the time came, power would find you."

Now the battle had become equal.

Ishaan raised his hand.

With his newfound power...

He created clones of his own.

Thousands.

Millions.

Billions.

An endless army of Ishaan clones stood against Manvik's countless copies.

The entire multiverse trembled.

Universes shook.

Stars collapsed.

Space-time itself quivered beneath the weight of the battle.

Clone after clone disappeared.

On both sides.

Hours passed.

Or perhaps centuries.

Time had no meaning inside the Nexus.

Until...

Only two figures remained.

The real Ishaan.

And the real Manvik.

Manvik made one final move.

He raised his Trident—still intact, still blazing with energy—and charged forward with everything he had.

Every ounce of hatred.

Every year of loneliness.

Every century of rage.

All released in a single strike.

Ishaan slowly rotated the Astra Ring.

Fifth Mode.

The mode he had never used before.

A light emerged.

It wasn't purple.

It wasn't blue.

It wasn't white.

It had no color.

It was simply...

Pure light.

Complete.

Absolute.

The Trident entered that light...

And vanished.

No explosion.

No sound.

It simply...

Ceased to exist.

Manvik froze.

For the first time in countless ages...

His eyes held something new.

Fear.

"This... this isn't possible," Manvik whispered, his voice trembling.

"It is," Ishaan replied calmly.

Completely calm.

Ishaan stretched out his gigantic hands.

He grasped the **Dimensional Nexus** itself—

The center of the multiverse.

The bridge connecting countless universes.

The source of Manvik's power.

With both hands...

He began to compress it.

Slowly.

Then harder.

"No...

NO!

YOU CAN'T DO THIS!" Manvik screamed.

The Nexus grew smaller.

Smaller.

And smaller.

Manvik's voice faded.

His existence—spread across countless universes for millions of years—began disappearing.

Little by little.

Like the final flame of a dying candle.

Until...

Only a tiny, radiant sphere remained.

The Singularity Sphere.

Small enough to fit inside a single hand.

Yet dense enough to contain the weight of the entire multiverse.

Manvik was gone.

Forever.

And with his end...

Every portal across the multiverse began closing.

The crimson sky slowly returned to blue.

The universes drifted back to their rightful places.

Space-time stabilized.

Everything...

Returned to normal.

Epilogue

After the Great War...

The world no longer saw Ishaan as an ordinary scientist.

Nor merely as a hero.

To humanity...

He had become the embodiment of a divine guardian.

But to Ishaan...

Nothing had truly changed.

The exhaustion remained.

The emptiness remained.

And the one person who mattered most...

Was still gone.

Professor Kenji returned to America and became the new Chief of NASA.

Anjali still lived in his memories.

But now there was peace within them.

As though something unfinished had finally come to rest.

Meanwhile...

A new sound echoed through Bhuvan and Mikhail's home.

Small.

Fragile.

Yet overflowing with life.

Their daughter had been born.

When Bhuvan called Ishaan—

"Brother... come meet her."

He came.

He looked at the tiny child.

And for the first time in a very long while...

He smiled.

A genuine smile.

Bhuvan asked softly,

"What should we name her?"

Ishaan looked at the baby.

Then at Bhuvan.

"Avika."

He answered quietly.

Bhuvan's eyes filled with tears.

Mikhail gently held his hand.

No one spoke.

Nothing needed to be said.

A few days later...

Late at night...

Ishaan stood alone inside the laboratory.

The monitors were still running.

SAHAY was active.

He looked through every invention he had ever created.

Every equation.

Every line of code.

Every design.

Then...

He pressed a single button.

One by one...

Every screen went dark.

He opened SAHAY's original interface—

The very first version he had built years ago...

While sitting alone on the last bench of his classroom.

"SAHAY."

"Yes, Ishaan."

"Thank you."

A brief silence followed.

"Always."

SAHAY replied.

Ishaan transferred the entire IKS organization to Om.

He left behind only a short letter.

You'll understand.

You always have.

Then...

He permanently shut SAHAY down.

The servers went silent.

He removed the Astra Ring...

And placed it gently on the table.

Then the Waqt-Bandh.

Only one thing remained in his hand.

Avika's bracelet.

On a foggy morning...

While the world was still asleep...

Ishaan walked out of the laboratory.

He disappeared down an unknown road.

He carried no Astra Ring.

No SAHAY.

No extraordinary powers.

No titles.

Only a silent man...

Holding a bracelet against his heart.

He was the greatest hero time had ever known.

The man who had saved the entire multiverse.

But in the end...

He remained only a quiet, incomplete lover...

Who vanished forever into the endless mist of time.

